

Government of Tamil Nadu
State Planning Commission



It's official. Tamil Nadu is the growth capital of India!

At 11.19%, Tamil Nadu's growth is nearly twice the national average!

Source - Economic Survey of Tamil Nadu 2025-26

Tamil Nadu's growth story is built on strong industry, inclusive growth and empowered people. By combining economic progress with social justice, the State continues to create opportunities, strengthen livelihoods and shape a prosperous future for all.



Manufacturing Powerhouse

Manufacturing grew at 14.74% and that is more than 3X the national average of 4.5%. Tamil Nadu leads India in manufacturing employment, accounting for 15% of the nation's factory workforce. When factories grow, jobs grow and families rise.



High Personal Income

Per capita income reached ₹3.62 lakh, which is 1.77 times the national average. That means stronger purchasing power, better lifestyles and financial security for households.



Employment Momentum

Unemployment declined to 3.5%, while labour force participation rose to 72.1%. More people are working. More people are earning.



Higher Education Leader

Tamil Nadu leads India with a 47% Gross Enrolment Ratio in higher education. Nearly 1 in 2 young people are in college, far above the national average of 28.4%.



Healthcare Champion

Infant mortality stands at 12 per 1000 live births, among the lowest in India. Life expectancy ranks among the highest nationally. Healthy citizens are the true measure of development.



Agricultural Strength

Agriculture contributes ₹1.9 lakh crore to the economy. Tamil Nadu ranks first in Ragi and Sugarcane yields. From farm to market, productivity means stronger rural incomes.



In Tamil Nadu's march to prosperity, we shall leave no one behind!

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MORE INFO**



ILLEGAL FIRECRACKER FACTORY
Seven killed in fire in Rajasthan; two injured
NEWS » PAGE 12

FRESH START
17 tourism destinations reopened in J&K
NEWS » PAGE 10





BNP'S STAND
'Hasina's presence in India won't deter ties'
WORLD » PAGE 14

M.K. STALIN WRITES
India's federalism is in need of a structural reset
Recalibration of Union-State relations
EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



MAKING THE CUT
Nissanka sends Lanka into the Super Eight
SPORT » PAGE 15

NEARBY


25 fishermen arrested by Sri Lankan Navy
KARAIKAL
The Sri Lankan Navy has arrested 25 fishermen from Karaikal in Puducherry, and Mayiladuthurai and Nagapattinam districts for allegedly fishing in Sri Lankan waters, and detained them at a naval base for questioning, sources said. **» PAGE 6**

Nagenthran expresses regret over his remarks
TIRUNELVELI
BJP State president Nainar Nagenthran on Monday expressed regret over his comments against actor Trisha Krishnan. **» PAGE 6**

NGT clears ₹92,000-cr. Great Nicobar project

The tribunal disposes of a batch of applications over environmental clearance for the project; says 'adequate safeguards' are provided in EC conditions and finds no good ground to interfere

Abhinav Lakshman
NEW DELHI

A Bench of the National Green Tribunal (NGT) on Monday cleared the way for the ₹92,000-crore Great Nicobar Island mega-infrastructure project, noting that "considering the strategic importance" of it and "other relevant considerations", "we do not find any good ground to interfere". It disposed of applications related to the environment clearance (EC) for the project, with a direction to authorities "to ensure full and strict compliance of EC conditions". The project includes a transshipment port, an airport, a power plant, and a township. The Bench was hearing a batch of applications re-



lated to the EC, which was granted in 2022. An earlier NGT Bench had in 2023 called for the formation of a high-powered committee (HPC) to address certain issues concerning the protection of coral reef colonies, nesting sites of leatherback turtles, and the allegation that parts of the project are located in ecologically protected zones. The applicants argued that the government had erred in limiting the terms of reference for the HPC to three issues and that the terms were "factually in-

correct". They said the issues had not been properly examined. The NGT said "adequate safeguards" had been provided in the conditions specified in the EC, which the tribunal had already refused to interfere with in its 2023 order. It said the remaining issues had "been dealt with" by the HPC. "A balanced approach is required to be adopted while considering the issue of allowing development of the port on a strategic location and taking adequate steps to carry out the activity strictly in terms of the ICRZ Notification, 2019 instead of prohibiting the activity if the objection is based on apprehension," the NGT said in its order. **CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10**

India's flagship AI summit opens to massive crowds

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

After months of promotion as India's flagship artificial intelligence event, the five-day AI Impact Summit was inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday, drawing overwhelming crowds and packing Bharat Mandapam to capacity as thousands thronged the venue. Officials had widely publicised the summit, hosting pre-event programmes across several Indian cities and abroad. Those efforts appeared to pay off on Monday, with nearly every accessible part of the sprawling 100-acre complex filled with attendees. "We have more than 2.5 lakh registrations," Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) Secretary S. Krishnan said on the sidelines. Entry to the event is free upon registration, and visitor passes have been over-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the inaugural event of AI Impact Summit at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi on Monday, ANI

subscribed, Mr. Krishnan said. In a post on X in the morning, Prime Minister Modi said, "The AI Impact Summit will enrich global discourse on diverse aspects of AI, such as innovation, collaboration, responsible use and more. I am confident that the outcomes of the summit will help shape a future that is progressive, innovative and opportunity-driven." Later in the afternoon, Mr. Modi visited the exhibition area, posting on X af-

terward that it was "a matter of immense pride for us that people from all over the world are coming to India for the India AI Impact Summit," and that the "occasion is further proof that our country is progressing rapidly in the field of science and technology and is making an important contribution to global development."

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10
RELATED REPORTS ON » PAGE 11

DMK wants Congress to act against Tagore before talks on seats

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

Ahead of the Tamil Nadu Assembly election, the long-standing goodwill between the ruling DMK and its ally, Congress, has suffered a severe jolt from the continuous accusations made against the ruling party by some Congress leaders, especially Virudhunagar MP Manickam Tagore and Praveen Chakravarthy. The DMK leadership, it is reliably learnt, appears to have prepared itself for the outcome, whatever it be. "Our leadership is not inclined to call the Congress for seat-sharing talks if action is not taken against the two leaders," a senior DMK leader told *The*

Hindu on Monday. "Our leader is upset. We are certain that Mr. Manickam Tagore would not target us and repeatedly demand a share in power without the blessings of the Congress high command. How do you expect us to hold seat-sharing talks with them after Mr. Tagore has criticised our leadership and the party," asked the leader. On Sunday, Mr. Tagore said the Congress bore the blame for the DMK's mistakes (in 2014) and the DMK had not acted against one of its district secretaries in Madurai who had said the Congress was free to leave the DMK alliance.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 6

Battle readiness



Field exercise: K-9 Vajra tanks showcase their artillery capabilities during the 'Vajra Ghaat' exercise, conducted by the Southern Command's White Tiger Division in the Pokhran Field Firing Range on Monday, ANI

SC Bench to review if new data law delivers a 'body blow' to RTI

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to refer to a Constitution Bench a series of petitions arguing that India's new digital personal data law delivers a "body blow" to citizens' right to a transparent and accountable government under the Right to Information (RTI) Act. Section 44(3) of the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act of 2023 imposes a "blanket ban" on the RTI Act applicants, preventing them from seeking disclosure of 'personal information', the petitioners said. They submitted that the provision cynically uses the right to privacy to cripple the citizens' right to information.

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, heading a three-judge Bench, refused a plea to pass an interim order to stay the implementation of Section 44(3), though the top judge said that the petitions raised a "complex, slightly sensitive and really interesting" question of law. "We may have to lay down what is meant by personal information," Chief Justice Kant remarked, issuing notice to the government.

'Unguided discretion'
Advocate Vrinda Grover, appearing for petitioner Venkatesh Nayak, submitted that the government, instead of using a chisel, used a "hammer to deliver body blows to citizens' right to information". Ms. Grover argued that Section 44(3) introduced by the DPDP Act has accorded the government "unguided discretion to



This is about balancing competing interests. We have to iron out the creases and lay down what constitutes personal information

SURYA KANT
Chief Justice of India



deny personal information, which is unconstitutional". In fact, the fundamental right to privacy has been extended to the State. The petitioners argued that Section 44(3) has amended Section 8(1)(j) of the RTI Act. Originally, the RTI provision had exempted authorities from disclosing personal information to an applicant if the details sought had no relationship to any public activity or if disclosure would amount to unwarranted invasion of privacy. Even then, the government had to disclose if public interest outweighed privacy. The decision whether or not to reveal 'personal information' was taken by a Public Information Officer or the First Appellate Authority under the RTI Act after thoroughly weighing privacy and transparency concerns. "Section 8(1)(j) of the RTI Act had struck the right balance between the right to privacy and the right to information," advocates Prashant Bhushan and Rahul Gupta, appearing for the National Campaign for People's Right to Information, submitted. **CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10**

Women's entry at Sabarimala temple: 9-judge SC Bench to commence review hearings from April 7

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday scheduled for hearing a series of review and writ petitions on a September 2018 judgment, which allowed women of menstruating age to enter the Sabarimala temple in Kerala, before a nine-judge Constitution Bench from April 7, 2026. A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said the maintainability of the review petitions had already been decided by an earlier nine-judge Bench constituted in 2019 by then Chief Justice of India Sharad A. Bobde. The



The Bench would hear the review petitioners challenging the 2018 judgment from April 7 to April 9. LEJU KAMAL

hearings before the Bench had to be aborted abruptly due to the onset of the COVID pandemic. The Supreme Court gave a brief timeline for the hearing of the case in April

2026. The Bench would hear the review petitioners challenging the 2018 judgment from April 7 to 9. Those opposing them would be heard from April 14 to 16. The rejoinder sub-

missions would be heard on April 21, followed by the concluding submissions from the *amicus curiae* on April 22. Parties have to adhere to the timeline, the court stressed. In November 2019, a majority judgment by a five-judge Constitution Bench led by then Chief Justice Ranjan Gogoi had referred the Sabarimala review and writ petitions to a seven-judge Bench. Over 60 review and writ petitions had challenged the Sabarimala judgment. The 2019 judgment had not expressly stayed the September 2018 verdict. The 2019 majority judgment had also clubbed si-

milar petitions concerning the essentiality of religious practices pending in the Supreme Court, including the right of Muslim women to enter mosques and the issue of female genital mutilation practised by the Dawoodi Bohra community, with the Sabarimala case. The judgment in 2019 framed legal questions in the case, including whether practices considered essential should be given constitutional protection and the extent to which the judiciary could intervene in an essential religious practice. **'WILL SEEK BALANCE' » PAGE 7**

Go to HC in case against Assam CM Himanta: SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday found "no good reason" to consider petitions for a criminal investigation into Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's alleged communal speeches and a deleted social media post depicting him shooting at animated Muslim figures. A three-judge Bench directed the petitioners to approach the Gauhati High Court instead. **FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 10**

GCC unveils first ‘Climate Budget’, plans outlay of ₹7,200 cr.

According to the report, the civic body has earmarked ₹3,190.61 crore towards capital expenditure for FY 2025-26; out of this amount, ₹1,341.2 crore has been identified as climate-relevant spending

ECO WATCH

R. Aishwaryaa
CHENNAI

Chennai's greenhouse gas emissions in 2050 are projected to increase by nearly four times over 2018 levels – to 55.08 million tonnes of CO₂ equivalent (tCO₂e) – if no additional mitigation measures are implemented, according to the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) 'Climate Budget' report. To address this, the report released on Monday stated that the

GCC had identified projects at an estimated cost of ₹7,200.53 crore, which is the cumulative expenditure required to plan, construct, and complete these activities over multiple financial years.

The report will be available on the official website of the civic body.

The report is among the announcements made by Mayor R. Priya in her Budget speech in 2025. Notably, for FY 2025-26, the GCC has earmarked ₹3,190.61 crore towards capital expenditure, of which ₹1,341.2 crore (42.04%) has been identi-

fied as climate-relevant spending, the report said.

This inaugural Climate Budget report has been prepared by the GCC's Financial Management Unit (FM Unit) with support from C40 Cities.

It spans 10 key departments within the GCC and integrates climate budgeting into the civic body's Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP) system, enabling systematic tracking of climate-related expenditure and strengthening institutional accountability, according to the Corporation.

According to the Chennai City Climate Action



Planning ahead: Chennai Mayor R. Priya and Deputy Mayor M. Magesh Kumar releasing the GCC Climate Budget report at Ripon Buildings on Monday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Plan (CCAP) released earlier, the average annual maximum temperatures could increase by 4.4°C and annual rainfall could rise by up to 27% by 2050. Sea levels are projected to rise by 0.11 metres by 2030

and 0.37 metres by 2050. For addressing this, the GCC aims for carbon neutrality and 'water balance' by 2050, the report said.

Targets for 2050

Specific targets for 2050 include a 100% renewable power for the grid, complete electrification of the Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) bus fleet, and fully decentralised waste processing. By 2050, the Corporation also intends to have all of the properties equipped with rainwater harvesting systems and all disaster relief centres rendered climate-

resilient. In the FY 2025-26 Budget, allocations for urban flooding and water scarcity management accounted for ₹834.75 crore (62.24%), the report noted. Apart from this, major on-going projects include the construction of 1,168 km of storm-water drains across nine zones, designed to handle rainfall of 68-72 mm per hour, at a cost of ₹5,553.3 crore.

Waste management initiatives received ₹350.81 crore (26.15%), focusing on the reclamation of legacy waste through biomining at the Kodungaiyur (₹640.83 crore) and Perun-

gudi (₹347.67 crore) dump yards.

Current project statuses indicate that phase two construction of the model and smart schools with energy-efficient designs is 10% physically complete and slated for conclusion in June 2026, the report said.

The restoration of the Kadapakkam Lake to double its water capacity is in progress. New initiatives in the planning stage include the establishment of rainwater harvesting systems at all GCC parks and plastic baling centres in 10 zones, the report added.

Climate justice must be centred on social inequality, say experts

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Conversations on climate justice must necessarily include questions of social justice, experts said at a webinar organised by the Climate Change Media Hub of the Asian College of Journalism.

The webinar 'Covering Heat: What Gets Missed' featured Apekshita Varshney, founder and executive director of Heat Watch, and Laurie Goering, extreme heat editor at Climate Resilience for All. The speakers called for rethinking how heat impacts communities, and urged journalists and policymakers to examine the working con-

ditions of those exposed to extreme temperatures and to design solutions grounded in lived realities.

Ms. Varshney said that in 2024, Heat Watch recorded 733 heatstroke deaths across 17 States between March and June. However, data presented by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare during the recent Lok Sabha session reported 360 deaths in the same 17 States between March 1 and July 25, pointing to discrepancies in official figures.

Ms. Goering said while outdoor workers faced direct exposure during heatwaves and were often advised to remain indoors, indoor heat posed a se-

rious risk as well. Those living in tin-roofed houses or other marginalised housing conditions experience intense indoor temperatures.

"Women in particular are at risk, as they spend long hours indoors cooking and caring for children," she said. The speakers also highlighted the growing threat of rising night-time temperatures. Vulnerable groups bore the brunt of prolonged heat stress, and women face heightened risks.

The session was moderated by journalist Shreya Raman. The Climate Change Media Hub is supported by Interlink Academy.

SBI to offer home loans at 7.1% interest for homebuyers attending FAIRPRO this year

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The State Bank of India (SBI) on Monday announced an attractive interest rate of 7.1% for home loans in Chennai at the 18th Edition of FAIRPRO 2026, which will be organised by Confederation of Real Estate Developers' Associations of India (CREDAI) from February 20 to 22 at the Chennai Trade Centre (CTC) in Nandambakkam.

Speaking at the press conference, Vivekanand Choubey, Chief General Manager, SBI, Chennai Circle, said: "This is to fulfil the dream of homebuyers. For new homebuyers and first-time homebuyers, es-



The residential market in Chennai remains strong and is supported by infrastructure growth and steady demand across segments

S. SIVAGURUNATHAN
Advisor, FAIRPRO 2026

pecially who are young, huge concessions are being provided by the bank – in processing charges and in rate of interest from 7.1% for CIBIL related scores. The best scores get 7.1 per cent and so on. Visit us on February 20, 21, and 22 for on-the-spot sanctions and

getting concessions in interest rates and processing charges."

K. Mothish Kumar, Convenor, FAIRPRO 2026, said: "With growing aspirations, rising demand, and renewed momentum in Chennai's real estate sector, FAIRPRO 2026 is poised to set new milestones in footfall, engagement, and business outcomes. With a large line-up of projects, exclusive deals, and SBI as the sole banking partner, FAIRPRO will be a one-stop destination for every homebuyer."

The exhibition will include 500 projects of 80 developers with a portfolio of 52,586 units across apartments, plots, villas,

and commercial spaces, sprawling over 57.2 million sq.ft. Prices for homes at the exhibition range from ₹15 lakh to ₹15 crore.

"Over the years, FAIRPRO has evolved beyond an exhibition to become a benchmark for credibility, transparency, and opportunity in property ownership," said Mohamed Ali, president, CREDAI Chennai.

"The residential market in Chennai remains strong and is supported by infrastructure growth and steady demand across segments," said S. Sivagurunathan, advisor, FAIRPRO 2026, and immediate past president, CREDAI Chennai.

CINEMA ARTS EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

Rasika Ranjan! Sabha Foundation, Ch-4. Today at 10am, Lec Dem Topic: Purandara Dasa - Historical Background, Bhakti and his Music by Prof. V. Aravinda Hebbar Ph. No: 86105 57987. Rasikas Welcome.

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THUSHARA SRINIVASAN (Disciple of Dr.
Padmavani and Sri. Jakkishore Mosalkanti)
7.00 p.m. Bharatanatyam by **SOUMITRA**
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INBRIEF



Conference on Tech and AI in Veterinary Medicine kicks off

Over 130 delegates from all over the country are participating at a three-day national conference on ‘Emerging Trends, Technologies, and Artificial Intelligence in Veterinary Medicine: Challenges and Opportunities’ which kicked off in the city on Monday. It was organised jointly by Indian Society for Veterinary Medicine (ISVM) and Department of Veterinary Medicine, Madras Veterinary College. Delivering the inaugural address, Major General S.S. Balaje, Director General, Remount Veterinary Services, outlined the importance of AI for precision diagnosis in veterinary medicine. R. Narendra Babu, Vice-Chancellor-in-charge and Registrar, Tamil Nadu Veterinary and Animal Sciences University (TANUVAS) also spoke. R. Ramprabhu, President, ISVM, Rajiv Gaikwad, general secretary, ISVM, P. Devendran, Dean, Madras Veterinary College, S. Satheshkumar, Dean, Faculty of Basic Sciences, TANUVAS, were among those present.

Libraries stand as one of the indicators of democratic development: N. Ram

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

“Today, the library is not just a repository of books; it is a digital access point, a media literacy centre, a community learning hub, a local knowledge archive, and it is an instrument, a force to combat a big disease we have today - misinformation and disinformation,” said N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group, at the inaugural ceremony of the fourth edition of the Indian Library Congress (ILC) held at the Anna Centenary Library on Monday.

CPI(M) MP V. Sivadasan and general convener of the event, said delegates participating in the sessions would discuss the expansion of libraries and ways to conduct outreach in rural areas across the country. “The number of libraries in India is not sufficient, and the investment in the promotion of libraries is very low. Together,



N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group, speaking at the Indian Library Congress in the city on Monday. R. RAAGU

we should take the initiative to increase investment in library sector and build a people’s campaign for the promotion of libraries, because library is the place for everyone,” he said. Mr. Ram, who is also the chairperson of the event, added that while knowledge was abundant today, access to it remained deeply unequal. “For example, Kannur alone has more registered public libraries than Uttar Pradesh and Bihar - so profoundly un-

equal among States and different sections of society. Therefore, public libraries stand as one of the indicators of democratic development in this country,” he said. He also touched upon the origins of the public library movement in Kerala and Tamil Nadu, the core democratic functions of a public library, including the significance of the Conemara Public library. He read the Preamble to the Constitution as a mark of

the official inauguration of ILC 2026. DMK MP R. Girirajan said reading should be encouraged through books rather than social media, which the younger generation must recognise. He said that with artificial intelligence, one may not even know what is true or false, and that reading is essential to combat this. Former MP L. Hanumanthaiah said that the main intention should be to ensure libraries are open to everyone, in every village, so that all citizens of the country have access to literacy and library resources. Former Tamil Nadu Chief Secretary V. Irai Anbu; S. Kamatchi, Chief Librarian & Information Officer (FAC), Anna Centenary Library; playback singer Pushpavathy Poypadathu; and other dignitaries – T. K. Govindan Master, Mridula Koshy, Sashi Kumar, Praveen VC, Prabhjit Kaur, P. K. Vijayan, Vijayakumar V. and Manu M.R., participated.

Fire breaks out at Nexus Vijaya Mall

CHENNAI: A fire broke out at the Nexus Vijaya Mall in Vadapalani on Monday morning. The mall administration deployed staff to control the fire. Fire and Rescue Services personnel rushed to the spot and fire tenders were engaged to control the blaze.

Timings			
CHENNAI			
TUESDAY, FEB. 17			
RISE	06:31	SET	18:15
RISE	06:18	SET	18:13
WEDNESDAY, FEB. 18			
RISE	06:30	SET	18:16
RISE	06:59	SET	19:06
THURSDAY, FEB. 19			
RISE	06:30	SET	18:16
RISE	07:39	SET	19:57

Chennai Weather		
Tiruvallur	32	18
Chennai Airport	32	22
Chennai City	31	23

Chennai Airport Today
31°C Morning will be pleasant. Day will be slightly warm. Night also will be pleasant. Dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
32°C The weather will be dry. Day will be little warm. Night will be slightly cool.

67% of work completed on CMRL’s phase II stretch from Koyambedu to Trade Centre

The stretch is scheduled to open in June this year, with viaduct work likely to be finished before the end of March; it will provide a second transit point between phase I and II networks at Koyambedu; along with this portion, stations on the Poonamallee-Vadapalani stretch too will be opened

TRACK TALES
Sunita Sekar
CHENNAI

Nearly 67 % of the work has been completed in Chennai Metro Rail’s phase II stretch between Koyambedu and Chennai Trade Centre, which is scheduled for opening in June this year. When train services begin in this stretch, Metro Rail connectivity will expand further, as a second transit point between phase I and phase II networks will be available at Koyambedu. In the 118.9-km phase II project, three corridors are shaping shape – Madhavaram to SIPCOT (corridor

3), Poonamallee to Light House (corridor 4), and Madhavaram to Sholinga-nallur (corridor 5). Initially, a section of corridor 4 from Poonamallee to Vadapalani will open within two weeks, providing the first point of interchange between phase I and phase II networks at Vadapalani. This will be followed by a section of corridor 5 from Koyambedu to Chennai Trade Centre. Along with this stretch, stations in corridor 4 between Alapakkam and Saligramam (a part of Poonamallee-Vadapalani stretch) will be opened in June as their construction will be completed only after four months. According to officials of Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL), the viaduct



Nearing completion: Of the 12 km of track to be laid between Koyambedu and Chennai Trade Centre, work has been done on nearly 2 km, say officials. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

work between Koyambedu and Chennai Trade Centre will be completed before the end of March. “We started the track work simultaneously in locations where the viaduct was finished. So far, out of

12 km of track to be laid between Koyambedu and Chennai Trade Centre, we have completed nearly 2 km, in locations including Mugalivakkam, Ramapuram, Chennai Trade Centre, and parts of the

double-decker corridor,” an official said. **Double-decker corridor** The double-decker corridor between Alapakkam and Alwarthirunagar, when fully ready in four months, will allow commuters to interchange trains at four stations – Alapakkam, Karambakkam, Valasaravakkam, and Alwarthirunagar – between corridor 4 and corridor 5. A few months ago, CMRL officials said they wanted to provide connectivity a little beyond Chennai Trade Centre till Alandur in June this year. This will offer one more train interchange point between the phase I and phase II networks at Alandur. But there is a major

hitch in establishing this connectivity, sources said. “Beyond Chennai Trade Centre, two stations – Butt Road and Alandur – have to be built. While construction of the Alandur station is under way, there are a lot of challenges in completing the Butt Road station before the June deadline. All these months, we couldn’t get traffic permission in a full-fledged way to carry out construction along Paul Wells Road. As a result, even pile work hasn’t begun at a few points in Paul Wells Road. It will be very difficult to finish the viaduct and the station at Paul Wells Road,” a source said. CMRL officials said such problems are getting resolved now and they will expedite the work.

THE HINDU
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IOLPL invites EOI from interested parties for partnering to set up POLYMER COMPOUNDING UNIT in India through a Joint Venture Model. EOI documents can be downloaded from our website from 17-02-2026 10.a.m onwards and Last date for submission is 09-03-2026 5.p.m (both days inclusive). Any Addendum / Corrigendum / Sale date extension in respect of above EOI shall be issued on our website: <https://indianoilling.com>; only and no separate notification shall be issued in the press. An online meeting for seeking clarification regarding EOI is scheduled on 25th Feb 2026 at 3:00 p.m. and interested parties may join the meeting via link to be published in the website. Interested parties are therefore requested to regularly visit our website to keep themselves updated. For clarifications, please mail to ennoirelmg@indianoilling.in

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CAT/GATE/GMAT/GRE/JAM scorecard obtained in the last three years, or DMAT (Data Science and Management Aptitude Test), which will be conducted in two phases — March 29, 2026 (Phase-1) and June 07, 2026 (Phase-2) — with the option to appear either online or offline exclusively at IIT Indore campus.
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INBRIEF



Annamalai cross-examines DMK leader T.R. Baalu

BJP leader K. Annamalai on Monday cross-examined senior DMK leader T.R. Baalu in a city court that was hearing a defamation complaint filed by the latter. Mr. Baalu had filed a complaint in the city court at Saidapet alleging that Mr. Annamalai defamed him at a press conference two years ago.



E-ticketing snag in MTC buses disrupts digital payments

A technical glitch disrupted the functioning of the electronic ticketing machines of the Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) in Chennai on Monday morning. Conductors were unable to accept digital payments or issue electronic receipts. Tickets were issued only in the printed form. S. Manohar, a commuter from Avadi, said he was surprised to see conductors accepting only cash payments. A senior MTC official said a software issue in the electronic machines prevented conductors from issuing tickets to commuters using the National Common Mobility Card or those paying through the Unified Payments Interface. However, commuters using the ‘Chennai One’ card of the Chennai Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority did not face any problems. The official said the problem was being resolved.

T.N. can be trillion-dollar economy by 2031 if it sustains 2024-25 growth: Economic Survey

The survey by the State Planning Commission highlights the ‘stellar performance’ of the State’s economy, while indicating areas of concern that need to be addressed to reach the desired twin targets of a trillion-dollar economy and per capita income on a par with developed countries

Sangeetha Kandavel
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu can become a trillion-dollar economy by 2031 if it sustains the 2024-25 nominal growth rate of 16%, “with an assumption of 2% (medium-term rate) rise in the value of the dollar against the rupee per annum”, according to the Economic Survey of Tamil Nadu 2025-26.

“With 3.5% short-term rate of rise of dollar value, it may be delayed for a year,” said the survey prepared by the State Planning Commission (SPC), with details from the Finance Department and subject experts.

The report was handed over to Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Monday.

Commenting on the second Economic Survey of the DMK government, J. Jeyaranjan, Executive Vice-Chairman of the SPC, said in his foreword that the State continued to focus on growth as well as social justice, resulting in a robust model for other States to emulate. “This unique model has resulted in a balanced sectoral growth. In fact, our double-digit growth recorded last year was spearheaded by the secondary sector, which our national economy and many other States aim to achieve,” he said.

The survey not only highlights the “stellar per-

formance” of the State’s economy but also indicates the areas of concern that need to be addressed to reach the desired twin targets of a trillion-dollar economy and a per capita income on a par with developed countries.

Textile exports

The 263-page report says the State’s textile exports, which account for a major share of all exports from Tamil Nadu, are facing headwinds owing to the recent 50% increase in the U.S. tariffs. Nearly 30% of the State’s textile exports are directed to the U.S.

“While this poses a temporary setback, the Union government’s suspension of the 11% customs duty on cotton until December 2025 offers a partial relief to the sector. At the same time, Tamil Nadu is actively diversifying its export markets to reduce dependence on traditional destinations and align with the shifting contours of global trade,” the report said.

The recent India-European Union (EU) free trade agreement and the India-U.S. trade agreement, by which U.S. tariffs on Indian goods will soon come down to 18% from 50%, may help in this regard.

Since February 2025, multiple rounds of U.S. tariffs and retaliatory measures heightened trade uncertainty. The global economy grew at 3.3% in



The Economic Survey says Tamil Nadu’s per capita income growth has consistently outpaced the national average. GETTY IMAGES

2025. India’s economy recorded 6.49% in 2024-25, but increased its growth performance to 7.4% in 2025-26. Despite global headwinds, Tamil Nadu remained resilient.

The Economic Survey also says Tamil Nadu’s per capita income growth has consistently outpaced the national average. In 2024-25, the per capita income reached ₹3.62 lakh, 1.77 times higher than the national average (₹2.05 lakh), making Tamil Nadu the third largest State in per capita income. Its Gross State Domestic Product at current prices reached ₹31.19 lakh crore in 2024-25, reflecting a nominal growth of 16% and a real growth of 11.2%, the highest among major States.

Fiscal policy has broadly supported Tamil Nadu’s growth trajectory. While the pandemic necessitated expansionary measures

that raised deficits and debt, subsequent years have seen stabilisation alongside a strong push for capital formation. Total capital expenditure between 2020-21 and 2025-26 amounts to ₹2.54 lakh crore, reflecting a decisive emphasis on asset creation.

“Although the debt-to-GSDP ratio remains below the thresholds recommended by the 15th Finance Commission, future pressures arising from pay revisions, pensions, and GST rationalisation could strain fiscal space. Sustaining growth will, therefore, require disciplined and productive use of resources,” the survey says.

Welfare programmes

The State government has consistently increased its expenditure on the social sector, from ₹1,13,268 crore in 2021-22 to ₹1,57,864

crore in 2025-26 (RE). Over the time, the State has built one of India’s most extensive and innovative welfare architectures.

Programmes such as Naan Mudhalvan, Pudhumai Penn, Tamizh Pudhalvan, the Chief Minister’s Breakfast Scheme, Kalaignar Magalir Urimai Thittam, and large-scale housing and urban renewal initiatives expand capabilities, reduce household risk, and strengthen aspirations. These interventions are not merely redistributive; they stabilise consumption, sustain domestic demand, and enable workers to avoid distress-driven employment.

According to the survey, urban inflation in Tamil Nadu declined from 5.2% in 2023-24 to 2.5% in 2025-26, while rural inflation fell from 5.8% to 2.1%. Urban inflation remains the primary driver of overall inflation in the State. Among major categories, food inflation plummeted to -0.003% in 2025-26, while inflation in clothing and footwear moderated to 1.3%.

“The Tamil Nadu government has worked to mitigate these effects through subsidised supplies of essential commodities such as cereals, pulses, edible oil, and electricity, along with income-support programmes including the Kalaignar Mahalir Urimai Thittam,” the survey says.

The manufacturing sector recorded a real growth of 14.74% in 2024-25, more than three times the all-India average of 4.5%. Over the four-year period from 2021-22 to 2024-25, Tamil Nadu led the nation with an average manufacturing growth of 9.38%.

Foremost contributor

The Economic Survey of India 2025-26 recognises Tamil Nadu as the foremost contributor to India’s manufacturing employment, accounting for 15% of the nation’s total factory workforce.

In 2024-25, the primary sector contributed 13.4% to Tamil Nadu’s Gross State Value Added, the secondary sector 33.1%, and the services sector contributed 53.6%. The services sector also registered a strong performance, achieving a double-digit real growth of 11.3% in 2024-25.

“Tamil Nadu continues to rank among the top Indian States in attracting foreign direct investment. While India’s overall FDI equity inflows declined from \$46.03 billion in 2022-23 to \$44.42 billion in 2023-24 amid global uncertainty and tighter financial conditions, Tamil Nadu defied the trend. Its FDI inflows increased steadily from \$2,169 million in 2022-23 to \$2,436 million in 2023-24, and further to \$3,681 million in 2024-25,” the survey says.

‘Key areas of agriculture need immediate attention’

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Several key areas in Tamil Nadu’s agricultural sector require immediate attention to ensure sustainable growth and resilience, says the State Planning Commission (SPC) in the State’s Economic Survey 2025-26.

Stating that since 2001-02, Tamil Nadu lost approximately two lakh hectares of net sown area and recorded a rise in fallow land, the SPC pointed to underutilised cultivable land, stressing the need for policies to reclaim the land left fallow.

Referring to the decline in surface irrigation sources, such as canals and tanks, accompanied by stagnancy in the net irrigated area, the SPC called for efficient groundwater management in view of wells, invariably used through electrified pumps, dominating the net irrigated area.

“Heavy dependence on

local markets for inputs and outputs underscores the necessity for enhanced sustainable input systems and market infrastructure development. Stagnation in yields of key crops such as paddy, pulses, and important fruits needs to be addressed to improve the livelihood of agricultural households,” the SPC said.

Lauding the livestock sector for showing “remarkable growth”, the SPC said this had emerged as a “key driver amid the declining fortunes” of the crop sub-sector. Its contribution to gross value added from agriculture, forestry, and fishing rose from 30% in 2011-12 to 53% in 2024-25.

“This sector needs attention through cold storage infrastructure development State-wide to curb wastage in marketing perishable products such as eggs, meat, milk, and fish, alongside strengthened support for sustainable practices and market lin-

Report card

A look at the average growth rate of sub-sectors of the primary sector since 2014-15

Sub-sector	2014-15 to 2018-19	2019-20 to 2020-21	2021-22 to 2024-25
Crop	0.09%	6.81%	3.03%
Livestock	13.42%	5.52%	3.89%
Forestry and logging	11.66%	11.4%	-2.12%
Fishing and aquaculture	4.23%	0.56%	6.05%
Mining and quarrying	17.01%	-20.75%	21.87%
Primary sector	5.65%	5.02%	3.85%

Primary sector’s share in Tamil Nadu’s GSDP (2011-12 prices)

Year	Share
2014-15	11.26%
2015-16	10.84%
2016-17	10.02%
2017-18	10.32%
2018-19	10.28%
2019-20	10.62%
2020-21	10.97%
2021-22	10.86%
2022-23	10.66%
2023-24	9.87%
2024-25	9.16%



kages,” it said.

Maize cultivation

Though paddy had retained its status as the dominant cereal crop of the State, maize cultivation went up significantly. Bet-

ween 2001-02 and 2023-24, it grew at a compound annual rate of 7.5%, with the area under maize going up by 3.6 lakh hectares from less than one lakh hectare in 2001-02.

This was “primarily be-

cause of its demand as poultry feed”. At the same time, all other cereal crops such as “cumbu, ragi, kora, varagu, and samai” have seen an absolute decline in area under cultivation over the period”.

‘Limited awareness’

The SPC said farmers’ awareness of the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for various crops remained limited. “[The] Survey evidence from 2018-19 suggests that around 68% of the agricultural households were unaware of the MSP for paddy and nearly 90% unaware of the MSP for maize, highlighting the need for improved dissemination of information and assured procurement to mitigate market risk.”

About 80% of the households relied on local markets for both input procurement and output sales, underlining the centrality of these market spaces and the urgency of investments in storage,

transport, grading, and trading infrastructure to enhance efficiency and farmer welfare.

Favouring the adoption of bio-inputs and less dependence on chemical inputs, the SPC said that despite the presence of a number of extension institutions, there were constraints in their outreach. This had only underscored the need for strengthening extension systems to ensure timely access to reliable technical knowledge.

In addition, only a small proportion of the households possess soil health cards, though “soil-specific nutrient management is central to both productivity and sustainability. Expanding soil testing capacity and strengthening soil health laboratory networks are, therefore, essential for promoting efficient input use and safeguarding the long-term ecological viability of agriculture in Tamil Nadu”, the SPC said.

Survey raises concern over consanguineous, child marriages in T.N.

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu’s marital landscape is still characterised by the prevalence of consanguineous marriages, according to the State’s Economic Survey 2025-26 of the State Planning Commission (SPC).

At 28%, Tamil Nadu reports the highest incidence among its peer States - Kerala, Karnataka, Gujarat and Maharashtra. As per estimates based on reports and fact sheets of the National Family Health Survey (NFHS) - 5, Tamil Nadu is followed by Karnataka with 26.6%, Maharashtra (14.8%), Gujarat (6.4%) and Kerala (4.4%). The all-India average is 10.8%.

Though Tamil Nadu’s visible pattern of marriage is attributed to the cultural factor, many Tamil feature films, knowingly or unknowingly, have been highlighting the aspect of consanguineous unions.

The survey acknowledges that the pattern carries “recognised genetic risks. Rising urbanisation and targeted public health communication may help reduce the prevalence of such unions”.

The report also says the concept of child marriages is still in vogue and has been defined by women, aged from 20 to 24 at the time of the survey, as getting married before the age of 18. In rural areas, the proportion of such women is 15.2%, and in urban areas, it is 10.4%. The State’s average stands at 12.8%, while the all-India average is 23.3%. The median age of women (in the age group of 25-29) at first marriage is 22 against the all-India average of 19.7.

In terms of access to education, female literacy

among women aged 15-49 has reached 84%, with 24.3% completing 12 or more years of schooling. These have been exceeded only by Kerala (97% and 30.4% respectively). The figures of all-India average are 71.5% and 16.6%.

Economic resources

As for access to economic resources, 92% of the women have their own bank or savings account - higher than the national average, as well as most peer States. Awareness of microcredit programmes is high with 74%, while 18% of women report taking loans from them, underscoring the deep penetration of financial inclusion programmes.

Digital and media exposure reveals a mixed picture. Tamil Nadu has the highest television viewership (83.4%) among its peers, but the lowest (14.5%) with regard to readership of the print media. Internet use among women remains modest (about 47%). The rural-urban digital divide is pronounced: only 69% of rural women own a mobile phone, and only 39% report using the Internet.

As for areas of concern, the State reports the highest proportion of pregnancies ending in non-live births (9.9%, compared to 6.5% in Kerala). This points to “persistent gaps in underlying maternal health conditions and quality of care”, the survey says. The next phase of women’s development requires a decisive shift from an input-driven approach to an outcome-driven governance model that evaluates whether programmes translate into meaningful improvements in empowerment, it says.

Parts of south T.N. likely to get heavy rain on Feb. 21, 22

K. Lakshmi
CHENNAI

The Bay of Bengal has witnessed only five weather systems that intensified into a depression in February since 1891.

This year, the low-pressure area is expected to become more marked and bring isolated heavy rainfall to parts of southern Tamil Nadu on February 21 and 22.

The low-pressure area, which has formed over the east equatorial Indian Ocean and the adjoining central parts of south Bay of Bengal, is likely to become more marked over southwest Bay of Bengal and the adjoining east eq-



Wet spell: The RMC has forecast isolated heavy rainfall in some parts of south-coastal Tamil Nadu and delta districts between February 19 and 22. R VENGADESH

uatorial Indian Ocean by Wednesday.

Citing records of cyclones and depression tracks, B. Amudha, Head,

Regional Meteorological Centre (RMC), said the most recent weather systems during February were seen in 1961, 1999,

and 2011. However, none of these developed into a cyclone.

February typically records very few rainy days and low rainfall totals across many districts. For instance, in Kanniyakumari district, February sees an average rainfall of only 7.9 mm, with a normal of just 0.7 rainy days. Similarly, Nagapattinam district gets an average rainfall of 13 mm, with a normal of 0.8 days. Nungambakkam in Chennai too receives a normal rainfall of 5.5 mm, with only half a rainy day.

However, there have been occasions when these districts recorded more than their average rainfall during this period.

Officials of the India Meteorological Department (IMD), New Delhi, said while the formation of a low-pressure area in February was not uncommon, the weather system intensifying into a depression was rare, and such systems largely impacted Sri Lanka.

Large-scale atmospheric phenomena, including Madden-Julian Oscillation, could also influence cloud cover and rainfall in the south Bay of Bengal and east Equatorial Indian Ocean, they said.

The current February system is likely to bring rainfall over Sri Lanka and parts of Tamil Nadu and Kerala, the officials added.

V.R. Durai, Director, Area Cyclone Warning Centre, RMC Chennai, said a strong temperature anomaly persisted in the east equatorial Indian Ocean. Warm sea surface temperature in the region this time had favoured the formation of a low-pressure area. However, the system is being monitored for further intensification.

The RMC has forecast a wet spell in south-coastal Tamil Nadu and delta districts between February 19 and 22.

“We have predicted isolated heavy rainfall in some delta and south Tamil Nadu districts, going by the weather models,” Mr. Durai added.

INBRIEF



Centre of excellence for cleft, craniofacial care inaugurated

A dedicated ‘Centre of Excellence for Comprehensive Cleft and Craniofacial Care’ was inaugurated by Dushyant Prasad, executive director, Akhila Bharatha Mahila Seva Samaja, at Sri Ramachandra Institute of Higher Education and Research (SRIHER) on Monday. The centre offers advanced and holistic treatment for patients with cleft lip, cleft palate, and complex craniofacial conditions. Naveen Kumar, director, Sri Ramachandra Comprehensive Cleft and Craniofacial Care Centre, said that the centre had been providing advanced treatment free of cost to the patients who suffer from cleft lip, cleft palate, and craniofacial anomalies for more than two decades. Till now, more than 20,000 patients had benefited from the treatment, Mr. Kumar said.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (February 17, Tuesday), the following articles are available:

- A separate classification for denotified tribes [newsth.live/denotifiedtribesexplained](#)
- Single genome-editing strategy promises to treat multiple disorders [newsth.live/genomestategy](#)

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Several fishermen, police personnel injured in fresh clashes near Kalpakkam

Fight broke out on Sunday over a land dispute between the fishing hamlets of Pudupattinam and Uyyalikuppam; senior officials conduct peace talks with villagers; CISF team deployed

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tension prevailed near Kalpakkam in Chengalpattu district on Monday after clashes between two fishing communities continued for the second consecutive day.

Sibin, Superintendent of Police (SP), Chengalpattu district, visited the spot and held talks with the residents.

Several fishermen from both sides and personnel from the Armed Police were injured in the clashes and were hospitalised.

Pudupattinam and Uyyalikuppam fishing hamlets, located close to each other near Kalpakkam, have been embroiled in a long-standing land dispute, which is already pending in court.

Every year, the *Mayana Kollai* temple festival is conducted in Pudupattinam. This year marked the 80th year of the festival and it was to be held on Monday. Preparations were under way for a milk-pot pro-



The windows of a house that were damaged during the clashes near Kalpakkam on Monday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The land dispute between the two fishing communities is pending in court

cession (*paalkudam*) to the Angalamman temple in Pudupattinam.

For the past two years, a dispute over what constitutes the common area has persisted between the fishermen of the two villages. When the milk-pot procession was organised on Sunday as part of the rituals, fishermen from Uyyalikup-

pam blocked it, stating that it should not pass through what they claimed to be “their territory”. As a result, the residents of Pudupattinam waited from morning without proceeding with the ritual.

Seeking a solution, more than 300 people staged a sit-in on Sunday. Revenue officials, led by senior police officers, held peace talks with representatives of both fishing panchayats, but no compromise was reached. Losing patience, members of both sides entered into a heated

argument, which escalated into a clash. Both sides threw stones at each other, leaving more than six persons injured. Villagers took the injured persons to the hospital.

Houses damaged

As tensions escalated, Armed Reserve and special police forces were deployed on Sunday night. Despite the security presence, fresh clashes broke out again on Monday morning between the two groups, leaving fishermen and one Armed Police personnel injured. During the violence, houses, household articles, and two-wheelers belonging to fishermen from both sides were damaged.

Accusing the police of failing to prevent the violence, fishermen from Pudupattinam staged a road roko and a sit-in demanding the arrest of those involved in the attacks.

Owing to the tense situation, the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) has also been deployed in the area, police sources said.

College students to be trained as scribes for Class 10, 12 exams

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The School Education Department has decided to appoint volunteers, mostly college students, as scribes for school students taking the public examinations.

The department has come out with new procedures, including Aadhaar verification of private candidates, among others.

School Education Minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi said second-year students from B.Ed. colleges, District Institutes of Education and Training (DIET), arts and science colleges, and engineering colleges, as well as *Illam Thedi Kalvi* volunteers would be appointed as scribes for students taking the public exam. “These scribes are being trained from the revision exams to make sure they are fully equipped for the boards,” he said here on Monday.

Mr. Mahesh held a meeting with School Education Department authorities to check the preparations for the State Board Public Examinations that will begin in March.

While 8,27,475 candidates will appear for the Class 12 Board Exam that will begin from March 2,

State Board Public Examinations to begin in March: Minister reviews preparations

9,09,002 candidates will appear for the Class 10 Board Exam on March 11 in Tamil Nadu. Of those appearing for the Class 12 exam, 7,99,692 will be school students and 27,783 private candidates. In the case of the Class 10 exam, 8,82,806 will be school students, while 26,196 will be private candidates.

A total of 281 prisoners will appear for the Class 12 exam and 395 for the Class 10 exam.

Flying squads

More than 49,000 teachers will be deployed on each examination day. Over 4,900 flying squads will also be deployed to prevent any malpractice.

Following the implementation of the State Education Policy, there will be no Class 11 public exam from this year. But the arrears exam for Class 11 will be held. A total of 25,051 candidates – 19,107 school students and 5,944 private candidates – will appear for that exam.

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The Andhra Pradesh Dairy Development Co-op Federation Ltd., Mangalagiri, Guntur intends to procure of Raw Milk Analyzer Cum Adulteration Testing Machines in districts of Andhra Pradesh. Interested parties may submit their bids on e-procurement platform @ [www.approcurement.gov.in](#) on or before **25-02-2026 by 5:00 PM**. The site will remain accessible to download the tender document w.e.f. **16-02-2026 from 10:00 AM onwards**. For further details the interested parties may contact during Office hours to Dy. Director (Projects), Phone No: 0863-2381085, e-mail: [etenders.apdcof@gmail.com](#).

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Notice Inviting Electronic Tenders

On behalf of President of India Principal Chief Materials Manager/PLW/Patiala invites tenders in electronic form for following items :-
e-Tender Notice No. 44 ET/2025-26

SN	Tender No.	Description	Qty.	Tender closing date
1	11265037	VVVF Drive Complete Bogie Testing Plant	01 Nos.	09.03.2026

Tender closing Time 15:00 Hrs.
The prospective tenderers are advised to visit the website [http://www.iireps.gov.in](#) or [http://www.plw.indianrailways.gov.in](#) for detailed description of items & other terms and conditions of tender document. Please note that tenderers can submit their quotations only through [http://www.iireps.gov.in](#).
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The project requirements, technical specifications, eligibility criteria, selection process, etc. are included in the Tender documents, which shall be available for download from the websites: [https://tender.nprocure.com/](#) and [https://www.gujarattourism.com](#) from 17/02/2026 onwards.

The last date for submission of the **Technical Bid and Financial Bid (online only)** is 16/03/2026 up to 6:00 pm. and **Technical Bid (physical only)** is 18/03/2026 up to 3:00 pm.

Managing Director

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Technical Agency के वचन हेतु
ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।

	कार्य का नाम	Mitigation Project for Lightning Safety (MPLS) के झारखण्ड राज्य में क्रियान्वयन हेतु Technical Agency के वचन के संबंध में
1	कार्य का नाम	Mitigation Project for Lightning Safety (MPLS) के झारखण्ड राज्य में क्रियान्वयन हेतु Technical Agency के वचन के संबंध में
2	ई-निविदा का बेवसाइट पर प्रकाशन की तिथि	20.02.2026
3	ई-निविदा प्राप्त करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय	18.03.2026, अपराह्न 6:00 बजे तक
4	ई-निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले कार्यालय का नाम एवं पता	आपदा प्रबंधन प्रभाग, टी.ए. डिवीजन बिल्डिंग, गोलचक्कर के नजदीक, धुर्वा, राँची, झारखण्ड, पिन-834004, कार्यालय दूरभाष संख्या-0651-2400218 ई-मेल disasteroffice-jhr@jharkhandmail.gov.in संयुक्त सचिव

गृह, कारा एवं आपदा प्रबंधन विभाग, (आपदा प्रबंधन प्रभाग), झारखण्ड, राँची

PR 373068 Disaster Management(25-26).D

GOVERNMENT OF TAMIL NADU MUNICIPAL ADMINISTRATION AND WATER SUPPLY DEPARTMENT
DIRECTORATE OF MUNICIPAL ADMINISTRATION, CHENNAI-28. Tel: 044-29864447
Notice for Inviting Tender (NIT)
(Roc.No. 25245/2025/P1, Date: 16.02.2026)

- Tenders are invited from the eligible bidders for Selection of concessionaire for redevelopment of old bus stand along with commercial development on Design, Build, Finance, Operate and Transfer (DBFOT) basis (for 45 years) under PPP Mode at Namakkal, Tiruchirappalli, Hosur and Tiruvananthai Corporations and Selection of concessionaire for development of commercial complex at Erode Central Bus Stand on Design, Build, Finance, Operate and Transfer (DBFOT) basis (for 45 years) under PPP mode at Erode Corporation.
- The details of tender can be obtained from web portal: [https://tntenders.gov.in](#)
- The RFP document can be downloaded from 19.02.2026 at the e-tendering Website [https://tntenders.gov.in](#)
- Pre-submission meeting will be held on 04.03.2026 at 3.00 pm in the Directorate of Municipal Administration, Urban Administrative Building, 75, Santhome High Road, MRC Nagar, Chennai-28.
- The last date for queries is up to 6.00 pm on 04.03.2026.
- The last date for downloading the RFP and the last date for uploading/ submission of bids is up to 3.00 P.M on 02.04.2026.
- The bids will be opened through online at 4.00 pm on 02.04.2026 at the office of concession Corporations.
- The value of each work, the details of Earnest Money Deposit and the eligibility of bidders shall be referred from RFP document.

Chief Engineer,
Directorate of Municipal Administration, Chennai-28.
DIPR/ 1132 /TENDER/2026

Indian Overseas Bank
Information Technology Department
Central Office: 763, ANNA SALAI, CHENNAI-600002

Indian Overseas bank (IOB) invites bids for the following:
GOVERNMENT E-MARKET PORTAL - Procurement & Operations of Trend Micro Extended Detection and Response (XDR) tool.

BID NO: GEM/2026/B/7229725 DATED 12.02.2026

The Above GEM Tender document is also available and can be downloaded from the following websites [www.iob.bank.in](#) & [www.gem.gov.in](#) For Tender details and future amendments, if any, keep referring to the following website [www.gem.gov.in](#)

GOVERNMENT OF PUDUCHERRY PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT

No.6721/PW/EE/BRC/DB/DR-/25-26 Puducherry Date: 16/02/2026
PRESS NOTICE FOR e-Tender

The Executive Engineer, Buildings & Roads (Central) Division, Public Works Department, Puducherry (Official email Id: [eebrcpud@py.gov.in](#)) invites on behalf of the President of India, online percentage rate bids from the approved and eligible contractors/firms for the following work: **1. N/W : “Improvements to the existing cement concrete road in Muthiyalpet Revenue Village, Puducherry.” Tender No.133/PW/BRC/25-26, Estimate Cost ₹ 5,11,15,456/- (inclusive of GST), Earnest Money ₹ 10,22,309/-, Last date and time of submission of bid on (or) before 11.00 AM on 23.02.2026. Date & Time of Opening of bid 11.30 AM on 23.02.2026.** The bid forms and other details can be obtained from the website [www.pudutenders.gov.in](#).

EXECUTIVE ENGINEER

No.825/DIP/AD(Press)/2025-2026

NATIONAL BOARD OF EXAMINATIONS IN MEDICAL SCIENCES
(Autonomous body of the M/o. Health & Family Welfare, Govt. of India) NAMS Building, Medical Enclave, Ansari Nagar, New Delhi – 110029

DNB-PDCET 2026

NOTICE

National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS) shall conduct the **DNB-PDCET 2026 on 12th April 2026**. The online applications are being invited from 17th February to 08th March 2026 at NBEMS website: [https://natboard.edu.in/viewnbeexam?exam=pdcet](#)

Candidate Care Support: • Helpline Portal on applicant login page +91-7996165333 • Communication Web Portal on NBEMS Website

NAGPUR METROPOLITAN REGION DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Station Road, Kingsway, Sadar, Nagpur-440001.
e-TENDER NOTICE No. 37/2025-26
[www.mahatenders.gov.in](#)

Sealed Percentage rate/ Item rate e-tenders are invited from Non-Registered /Registered Contractors with N.M.R.D.A./ N.I.T./P.W.D./ N.M.C. or other Govt. Dept. as per eligibility criteria for **One** work. The details of works will be uploaded on tender website i.e. [www.mahatenders.gov.in](#)

Sr. No.	Name of Work	Amount of Work / E.M.D. in Rs.	Eligibility/Tender Cost in Rs.	Time Limit in Months	Division
1	Appointment of Consultant for “Providing Comprehensive Architectural & Engineering Consultancy Services including Masterplan, Internal Infrastructure, External Development & Landscape, Detailed Project Report on the Sustainable Model etc. for Development of Naveen Nagpur on 1710 Acres Land.”	As per Tender Document 10,00,000/-	As per Tender Document 29,500/-	36	Town Planning

Money:- E.M.D. is to be paid by online only. **Plans & Estimates :-** Available in the Technical Section, Head Office, Sadar, Nagpur. **Tender Forms :-** From 02.00 P.M. on Date 18.02.2026 up to 2.00 P.M. on Date 11.03.2026 on [www.mahatenders.gov.in](#) **Receipt / Submission :-** From 02.00 P.M. on Date 18.02.2026 up to 2.00 P.M. on Date 11.03.2026 on [www.mahatenders.gov.in](#). **Pre-Bid Meeting:-** On 4.00 P.M. on Date 26.02.2026 in the Office of S.E. (Project), NMRDA, Station Road, NMRDA, Head Office, Sadar, Nagpur. **Opening :-** At N.M.R.D.A. Office on Date 12.03.2026 at 2.00 P.M. or as decided by N.M.R.D.A. **-sd- Superintending Engineer, Advt. No.: S.E.(NMRDA)/85/2025-26 Dated : 16.02.2026 Nagpur Metropolitan Region Development Authority**

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER Drinking Water and Sanitation Mechanical Division, Dhanbad

Short Notice Inviting e-Quotation
Notice No:-05/2025-26

Government of Jharkhand through its Public Works Department (PWD) is engaged in framing/ revision of Schedule of Rates and as part of this endeavor, quotations through e-tender are invited for “**Material**” **Supplying, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of Pump Set and allied works at Rural Water Supply Scheme Mairanwatand and Qjhadih-Katania** Works pertaining to drinking water supply from Reputed Manufacturers/Authorized Dealers for respective items conforming to the specifications for inclusion in the Schedule of Rates for Government of Jharkhand to be used in different Civil construction/ infrastructure works and repair works shall be submitted online in the website [http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in](#), Details and list of materials are available on the above e-tender portal. The quotationer may download the documents from the website and quote their firm item rate excluding taxes for the Materials online from 20.02.2026 at 02:30 hrs. to 06.03.2026 at 05:00 hrs. The quotation will be opened on 07.03.2026 at 05:00Hours.

The quotation is invited to ascertain and assess the Rate of Materials at par with lowest market rate for framing of Schedule of Rate.

Address for Communication:-
Office of the Executive Engineer
Drinking Water & Sanitation Mechanical Division, Dhanbad.
Address : Near Kumar Fuels Opp. Water Tower, Dhansar, Dhanbad- 828106.
Landline No : 0326-2308988
e-mail ID : [ec.mechdivisiondhanbad003@gmail.com](#).

Executive Engineer, D.W. & S. Mechanical Division Dhanbad.

PR 373077 Drinking Water and Sanitation(25-26)#D

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PERSONAL ANNOUNCEMENTS	PUBLIC NOTICE
I, S.SARAVANAN , Ex-Army Service No.15314108N, Rank: HAV, Residing at Ramakoti Street, Kumarakuppam Village, Tiruttani Post & Taluk, Tiruvallur District Pincode 631209 have changed my Spouse Mrs. M. Shobha date of birth from 06.06.1979 to 05.06.1979 Vide affidavit dated: 04/02/2026	It is hereby informed to the general public at large that our Client is intending to acquire all that piece and parcel of land totally measuring an extent of 3.293 Sq.Ft (3,277 Sq.Ft as per TSLR Patta), with the residential building having built up area of 2,420 sq.ft., bearing Plot No.9, Door No.16, Vannanthurai Road, situated in SBI Officer's Colony, Sastrinagar Scheme, Layout No. L.A. No.66/68-69, dated 08.06.1969, B.A. No. P.1783/69 dated 12.08.1966, comprised in Old S.No.103/B, R.S.No.103/1 (part), T.S.No.1/16, Block No.38, situated in Urur Village, Velachery Taluk, Chennai District, and situated within the Registration District of Chennai South and Sub-Registration District of Adyar, presently owned by Mrs. Revathy Ramakrishnan, and the land being bounded on the: North by : Lands in Block No.27 South by : Lands in T.S.No.1/1 (State Bank Colony Road) East by : Lands in T.S.No.9 West by : Lands in T.S.No.1/4
I, J. Aravin Selva , son of Late S. Johnson, residing at No.93/10, Bhuvaneshwari Nagar, 1st Main Road, Velachery, Chennai – 600042, Tamil Nadu, have changed my name to J. Arvin Selvam for astrological reasons. Henceforth, I shall be known as J. Arvin Selvam.	Any person(s) or entity(ies) (a) having or asserting any right, title, claim or interest by way of Agreement, sale, settlement, exchange, lease, license, mortgage, inheritance, gift, lien, charge, maintenance, easement, trust, possession or otherwise of any nature whatsoever over the aforementioned property or any portion(s) thereof; and/or (b) having any objection(s) of any manner whatsoever to the acquisition of the aforementioned property are hereby called upon to notify the undersigned in writing with documentary proof of the same within 12 (Twelve) days from the date of publication of this notice. Any claims or objections received thereafter shall be deemed to be forfeited / waived and shall not be entertained in any manner whatsoever and our Client would be at liberty to proceed with the transaction free from all claims and encumbrances. P.V.Sajji Kumar, R.Ganesan, A.Hari Karthik, Advocates, Dua Associates, Advocates & Solicitors, "Palani Centre", No.32, Venkatanarayana Road, T.Nagar, Chennai - 600017.
I, G A Bharani S/O, G V Aswini Kumar R/o No.278, 3a- Gautama Flats, 11 Th Street, Tribh Colony, Korattur, Chennai-600080 have changed my name to G Bharanidhar.	PALLIATIVE CARE at your home Trained Nurses, 24/7, Dr. Physio visits, Lab tests 1800-313-1883 tikotra.com/seniors
I, BIJU SHAJI SHAJI, DOB:13/10/1973, W/O Mr.Shaji Shahul Hameed Residing at No.12B, 5th Cross Street, Andal Nagar, Adambakkam, Chennai:600088, Tamil Nadu, India. I hereby declare that I have changed my name to BIJU P NOOR Henceforth, I shall be Called BIJU P NOOR for All purposes.	THANKSGIVING MAY The sacred of Jesus be Adored Glorified, Loved & Preserved throughout this world now & forever. Sacred of Jesus thy will be done. St Jude worker of Miracles pray for us StJude Helper of the hopeless pray for us. Call: 9841737257
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P/104/2025-26 Date: 17-02-2026

E-TENDER NOTICE
E-tenders are invited for the supply of I) Raw Materials for the period 01-04-2026 to 30-09-2026 and II) Containers & Packing Materials for the period 01-04-2026 to 31-03-2027. Tenders can be downloaded from the website [www.etenders.kerala.gov.in](#). For more details, please visit our website [www.oushadhi.org](#) or contact our Purchase Division at Kuttanellur, Thrissur (Sd/- Managing Director

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Tamil Nadu

From Page One

DMK wants Congress to act against Tagore

The meeting of the Madurai South District unit of the Congress, in which Mr. Tagore participated, also adopted a resolution demanding a share in power.

The DMK leadership also suspects that the Congress may be keeping its options open because some leaders are reportedly interested in aligning with actor Vijay’s Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK).

A Congress MP agreed that Mr. Tagore would not target the DMK without the blessings of either Rahul Gandhi or other leaders in Delhi. “As a party, we have the right to take a political decision. But had we been interested in quitting the alliance, we should have prepared the ground at least a year ago. If we leave now, it will only help the BJP-AIADMK combine,” he said.

A DMK MP said that be it *Kalaigarnar* (M. Karunanidhi) or *Thalapathy* (Mr. Stalin), they had always been accommodative of the Congress, and there was nothing that could not be resolved through negotiations. “We have conveyed our stand to the Congress leadership that power-sharing is not possible. The Chief Minister also made our position clear at a public forum. Still, Congress leaders are deliberately making noises, which will not augur well for the alliance,” the MP said.

TNCC president K. Selvaperunthagai said the high command had already cautioned leaders against talking about the alliance in the open. “It had formed a five-member committee, which will hold seat-sharing talks with the DMK,” he said.

Mr. Selvaperunthagai met AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge in Bengaluru on Monday night to brief him of the developments. However, a section of Congress leaders in the State argued that Mr. Tagore’s comments only reflected those of the cadre. A Congress MP believed that the “alliance was heading for a crash”. He felt that the Congress should have raised “people’s issues” and then forced a split with the DMK based on those issues instead of citing personal grievances of leaders over “lack of respect” and other aspects.

Former TNCC president K.S. Alagiri told *The Hindu* that staying in the DMK alliance would be the right decision as Mr. Stalin was a better choice for Chief Minister than others. “However, if we don’t change our strategy, the Congress has no scope to grow. The DMK talks about federalism and decentralisation. The Congress has been a long-time friend, and there is nothing wrong in accommodating the Congress in the Cabinet,” he said.

(With inputs from Udhav Nair)

‘Better for Congress to remain in DMK-led front for its own sake’

The Congress has raised the issue of power-sharing in Tamil Nadu at an inappropriate time, says CPI(M) State secretary P. Shanmugam

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

CPI(M) Tamil Nadu secretary P. Shanmugam on Monday said the Congress had raised the issue of power-sharing in Tamil Nadu at an inappropriate time. According to him, it would be beneficial to the alliance as a whole, and the Congress itself, if the party stayed in the DMK-led front.

When asked whether the Congress quitting the alliance would weaken the coalition, Mr. Shanmugam said an important party quitting a front would result in some damage to the coalition. “But I do not think it will affect the victory of the DMK-led alliance,” he said.

Explaining why he felt it was inappropriate for the Congress to raise the issue of power-sharing at this juncture, he said that after the election, this issue would naturally become a matter of discussion if the DMK failed to secure a majority and was compelled to seek the support of the allies to form a government. “At present, there is no need to make such a demand. It would be a different issue if there were to be a coalition government based on a common minimum programme or a common manifesto. In the coming election, the DMK-



Impact assessment: Shanmugam says the Congress quitting the DMK-led alliance will not affect the prospects of the coalition.

led alliance has no such plans. Under these circumstances, demanding a share in power in advance is inappropriate,” he said.

Mr. Shanmugam added that the CPI(M) would not take part in a coalition government, as its policy was not to be part of a government led by another party.

When asked whether the Congress was seeking to leverage the presence of actor Vijay’s Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, he said some Congress leaders might harbour ambitions of joining hands with the TVK. “They are expressing their views openly. However, the final decision will be taken only by the Congress high command in Delhi. So far, senior leaders, including Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi, have not spo-

ken in favour of aligning with the TVK or demanding a share in power in the DMK-led alliance. We cannot conclude that the Congress has other plans merely because some leaders in Tamil Nadu are raising the issue. It may well be a strategy to bargain for more seats,” he said.

Mr. Shanmugam said Mr. Vijay would secure some percentage of votes – perhaps more than others who started political parties and tested the waters – but it might not translate into seats. It was natural for young people to attend Mr. Vijay’s meetings, given his popularity as a film star, he said. “The crowd largely comprises students and youngsters. It reflects the popularity he has gained through cinema,” he said.

Madras HC to hear Ponmudy’s petition on I-T assessment after two weeks

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Wednesday decided to hear after a fortnight a writ petition filed by former DMK Minister K. Ponmudy, who had challenged an assessment order passed by the Income Tax (I-T) Department in December 2022 after coming to the conclusion that an illegal payment of ₹20 lakh had been made to him by SRS Mining, owned by J. Sekar Reddy and two other partners.

Justice C. Saravanan directed the High Court Registry to print the name of I-T Department senior standing counsel A.P. Srinivas in the causelist, and list the case after two weeks. The former Minister had filed the writ petition in January 2023 challenging the assessment order passed by an Assistant Commissioner of Income Tax, and a consequent notice of demand issued on December 22, 2022.

On January 30, 2023, Justice Abdul Quddhose had passed an interim order restraining the I-T Department from taking coercive steps against the former Minister until further orders, and granted time for the department to file its counter affidavit. The court granted the interim relief after being *prima facie* convinced with the submissions made by senior counsel P. Wilson, re-



K. Ponmudy

presenting the writ petitioner.

The senior counsel had told the court that the I-T Department had issued multiple show cause notices before passing the assessment order. While responding to those notices, the petitioner had requested the department to share the evidence to prove that he had received the illegal payment. However, the department was unable to share any evidence, he claimed.

Mr. Wilson had also drawn the attention of the court to the fact that though the petitioner had requested the I-T Department to permit him to cross-examine the partners of SRS Mining, the department had refused to accede to his request.

The court was also told that the demand made in the show cause notices was only for a sum of ₹20 lakh, but in the final assessment order, the tax liability, along with interest, had been arbitrarily increased to ₹78.33 lakh.

Religious public trusts exempted from purview of Tenants Act

Dennis S. Jesudasan
CHENNAI

The State government has exempted premises owned by Hindu, Christian and Muslim religious public trusts and public charitable trusts from the provisions of the Tamil Nadu Regulation of Rights and Responsibilities of Landlords and Tenants Act, 2017. An order was issued by the Housing and Urban Development Department recently.

In view of the increased growth of the real estate sector, broad-based home ownership and availability of more housing stock, the State government enacted the Tamil Nadu Regulation of Rights and Responsibilities of Landlords and Tenants Act, 2017 by repealing the Tamil Nadu Buildings (Lease and Rent Control) Act, 1960. The Act was amended in 2018 and the amended Act was notified in February 2019.

It came into effect from February 2019 only in urban areas initially, and eventually in all villages with effect from February 2021. It was later amended with regard to restriction on sub-letting, consequences of violation of duties, and eviction, with effect from June 2022. The Act aims to regulate rent as per the terms and conditions of the agreement between the owner of the premises and the tenant, and seeks to balance the rights and responsibilities of the landlord and the tenant.

Nagenthran expresses regret over comments about Trisha

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUNELVELI/CHENNAI

BJP State president Nainar Nagenthran on Monday expressed regret over his unsavoury comments against actor Trisha Krishnan.

Addressing the media in Palayamkottai, Mr. Nagenthran said, “Our party’s women’s wing president and MLA Vanathi Srinivasan and former State president K. Annamalai spoke to me in this regard. It [the comment against Ms. Trisha] was uttered by mistake. If my comments had hurt anyone, I sincerely regret those remarks.”

Earlier in the day, Ms. Trisha issued a statement through her legal counsel, condemning the BJP leader’s comments without naming him.

“My client [Trisha] never expected that such distasteful and inappropriate remark would be made by a person holding a high stature in the State’s political space. My client makes it very clear that she is not affiliated with any political party, neither does she intend to be. Further, just as my client had continuously maintained in the past, she has always taken a neutral stand when it comes to politics,” the statement said.

“My client wishes to be defined only by her craft and not by any alleged political alignment. Further, it is a common saying that personal lives should never be made the subject of public commentary or discourse, and it is expected that persons holding high positions maintain responsibility and equanimity in public discourse,” it said.

Panel on Union-State relations submits initial report to Stalin

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Justice Kurian Joseph-led high-level committee on Union-State relations, constituted by the Tamil Nadu government, submitted the first part of its report to Chief Minister M.K. Stalin at the Secretariat in Chennai on Monday.

The report made a case for decentralisation and State autonomy, and outlined issues relating to amendments to the Constitution, territorial integrity of the States, the Governor, and delimitation, among other matters.

“The report undertakes a detailed examination of contemporary federal

challenges and advances concrete, actionable recommendations aimed at restoring federal balance and strengthening genuine cooperative federalism within the constitutional framework. Two further parts, comprising ten chapters each, are under preparation,” an official release issued by the government said.

‘Important milestone’

In April last year, the government had constituted the committee with retired Supreme Court judge, Justice Kurian Joseph, as its chairperson. Retired IAS officer K. Ashok Vardhan Shetty and former Vice-Chairman of the Tamil Na-



Suggesting solutions: Members of the Justice Kurian Joseph-led committee submitting the report to Chief Minister M.K. Stalin.

du Planning Commission M. Naganathan were its members.

An official release from the State government said the submission of Part I of

the report marked an important milestone in Tamil Nadu’s continuing engagement with the evolution of India’s federal structure. “The objective is not to

weaken the Union, but to right-size it – enabling it to focus on genuinely national responsibilities while restoring to the States the autonomy essential for effective governance and aligning authority with responsibility,” it said.

“A Union that diffuses its energies across functions better performed by States and local bodies risks distraction from the larger national challenges that only it can address. The Government of Tamil Nadu hopes that this report will stimulate informed dialogue and contribute to a more balanced and cooperative federal order,” it added.

Efforts were also on to

translate Part I into major Indian languages, including Assamese, Bengali, Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Odia, Punjabi, and Telugu, to facilitate wider national engagement.

After the report is placed before the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly, the Tamil version of the report would be uploaded on the official website of the State government. “Any individual or institution may print, reproduce, or distribute the Tamil text, in whole or in part, from the official PDF, provided that the source is duly acknowledged and no alterations are made,” the release said.

The Justice Kurian Joseph committee marked the fourth major national-level review of Union-State relations, and the second undertaken by Tamil Nadu, which earlier led the discourse through the Rajamannar Committee (1969-71).

At the national level, the Sarkaria Commission (1983-88) and the Punchhi Commission (2007-10) examined Union-State relations and made significant recommendations. “The passage of time since those inquiries, together with substantial Constitutional, fiscal, and institutional developments, necessitated a fresh and comprehensive review,” the release said.

Aequs Group set to invest ₹4,000 crore, NMB-Minebea India ₹1,980 crore in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government has signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with Aequs Group for an investment of ₹4,000 crore to create a 250-acre aerospace and defence cluster at SIPCOT Shoogaligiri in Krishnagiri district.

It has also inked an MoU with NMB-Minebea India Private Limited for an investment of ₹1,980 crore in Tiruvallur district.

Both MoUs were signed in the presence of Chief Minister M.K. Stalin at the Secretariat in Chennai on Monday. Taking to social media, Industries Minister T.R.B. Rajaa said the Aequs project would be India’s first fully vertically integrated aircraft engine manufacturing project. It would create 7,000 jobs,

The Aequs project would create a 250-acre aerospace and defence cluster at SIPCOT Shoogaligiri

he said. “The project will include an Aerospace and Defence Park with integrated facilities for aircraft engine and gearbox components manufacturing. It will house shared industrial infrastructure to create a seamless production and export platform,” Mr. Rajaa said.

With regard to the investment by NMB-Minebea India Private Limited, the Minister said Japanese companies continued to reinforce their faith in Tamil Nadu. Minebea Mitsumi was a global player in precision mechanical and electronic components, with operations across 28

countries, supplying critical components to automotive, industrial and electronics sectors worldwide, he said.

“This investment strengthens our precision engineering and electronics ecosystem and deepens our integration into global supply chains. Tamil Nadu continues to be the preferred destination for advanced electronics manufacturing,” Mr. Rajaa said. At another event at the Secretariat, Mr. Stalin virtually inaugurated 16 Uzhar Angadis, established in Chennai and its peripheral areas to facilitate market opportunities for farmers and ensure the availability of good quality food for consumers.

He also presented orders to entrepreneurs for setting up 54 value-added units for agricultural produce. He also flagged

off tractors, rotavators, and other equipment procured by the Agricultural Engineering Department to be provided to farmers at nominal rates.

Mr. Stalin also virtually inaugurated buildings constructed for the Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare, Health and Family Welfare, Higher Education, Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises, Social Welfare and Women Empowerment, and Welfare of Differently-Able Persons Departments at a cost of ₹1,210 crore. He also laid the foundation for the construction of new buildings for the Higher Education Department at a cost of ₹555 crore.

The Chief Minister also presented the Kalaigarnar Nainaivu Kalaithurai Vithagar Award to actor M.N. Rajam and film-maker S.P. Muthuraman for 2024 and 2025.

25 fishermen from Puducherry, T.N. arrested by Sri Lankan Navy



In troubled waters: One of the two groups of fishermen arrested by the Sri Lankan Navy.

The Hindu Bureau
KARAikal

The Sri Lankan Navy has arrested 25 fishermen from Karaikal in Puducherry, and Mayiladuthurai and Nagapattinam in Tamil Nadu, for allegedly fishing in Sri Lankan waters.

The fishermen, who had set out in two mechanised boats from the Karaikal fishing harbour, were taken to the Kankesanthurai

naval base for questioning, sources said.

According to the sources, one of the boats had 14 fishermen on board, including one from Mayiladuthurai district and five from Nagapattinam district. It had set out from the Karaikal fishing harbour on February 15.

The second boat, with 11 fishermen, including two from Mayiladuthurai and seven from Nagapattinam,

had left the harbour on February 11.

Remanded in custody

The fishermen were apprehended by the Sri Lankan Navy for allegedly crossing the International Maritime Boundary Line.

Sources said the fishermen were produced before a court at Mallagam in Sri Lanka, and remanded in judicial custody till February 27.

CM
YK



Cities of debt

ULBs need more administrative capacity before they can tap the market

The government’s updated ‘Urban Challenge Fund’ has rendered the attention of urban local bodies (ULB) an even more precious resource as they struggle to complete unfinished work under other schemes, including AMRUT, Swachh Bharat Mission Urban 2.0, ‘Smart Cities’, and Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, which also suffer from chronic underutilisation. The government has pitched the fund as a move towards “market-linked, reform-driven and outcome-oriented” urban infrastructure, with the Centre covering 25% of project cost if cities raise at least 50% through bonds, loans, and PPPs. This is an attempt to incorporate fiscal discipline in a system that has never properly devolved fiscal powers to ULBs. Many Indian cities cannot credibly borrow without first fixing the political economy of local taxes and transfers, which are shaped by State-level issues and under-investment in municipal capacity. Requiring cities to “earn” their growth risks sidelining weaker ones and shifting the focus from services such as formalising settlements to developing monetisable assets. The ₹5,000 crore guarantee may ease borrowing for smaller cities, but proper accounting and administrative capacity are essential. When a Parliamentary Standing Committee asked about the Fund’s eligibility criteria and application process, the Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry said that it was still “under examination”, a possible recipe for politically coloured spending.

Across sectors, the Centre has, since 2014, increasingly reduced the share of public support while asking public systems to fill the gap using private finance. The CSIR was among the first casualties and urban development could be the latest. In higher education, the move towards infrastructure loans turned public universities into debt-laden entities that were expected to recover costs by increasing fees, affecting poor students. Studies of the National Health Mission’s financial management have documented long delays to move funds through treasuries to implementing agencies, so in practice, hospitals have been asked to maintain services first and receive money later. Audits under the Ujwal DISCOM Assurance Yojana have exposed significant non-adherence and implementation gaps in the power sector. Private capital is not illegitimate and public systems should sometimes raise revenues; the issue is that the Centre increasingly conditions public support on market access instead of ensuring minimum service guarantees first. Thus, while the Fund’s instruments are legitimate, it will increase the risk of becoming insubordinate to “bankability” if land records are a mishmash, ULBs routinely violate ‘master plans’, and renters and low-income households do not receive additional protections.

Transatlantic strains

Europe should engage with the wider world to reduce dependence on the U.S.

The international rules-based order “no longer exists”, Germany’s Chancellor Friedrich Merz said at the annual Munich Security Conference. French President Emmanuel Macron called for greater European “military autonomy”, arguing that the continent must become a stronger pillar within NATO. While these remarks reflected Europe’s growing anxiety over the U.S.’s receding security commitments, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio promised a path of cooperation. He advocated a stronger alliance rooted in shared history and Christian cultural linkages rather than shared strategic interests. The speeches by European and American officials underscored both the strains in transatlantic ties and Europe’s mounting challenges. Last year, at the same venue, U.S. Vice-President J.D. Vance had slammed Europe’s democratic model and its refugee policies. Mr. Rubio, though conciliatory, also echoed the American far-right’s central talking point of “civilizational erasure”. The Trump administration wants Europe, at a moment of crisis, to join its culture wars and its push to reassert western dominance.

Today’s Europe faces a trifecta of challenges. First, the largest land conflict since the end of the Second World War has been raging on its eastern flank for four years. Europe’s principal response has been to arm Ukraine and hurt Russia through sanctions, but this has not produced decisive results on the battlefield. Second, Europe has relied on the U.S. for its security since the Second World War, a dependence that deepened after the Cold War. This lopsided partnership is no longer sustainable as the U.S., where a new far-right movement seeks to recast transatlantic ties, appears increasingly less committed to European security. Mr. Trump’s remarks about taking control of Greenland risk undermining the alliance’s collective defence principle. Third, resurgent far-right movements across Europe are challenging the idea of an inclusive European Union. As the global order shifts – as Mr. Rubio said ahead of Munich – Europe risks being squeezed by these cross-currents. Instead, Europe has to reduce its reliance on the U.S. and build greater strategic autonomy. And if it is worried about the breakdown in the international order, it should help rebuild that by working with countries beyond the West. In the near term, Europe must also work towards ending the war in Ukraine and establishing a workable new normal with Russia. Finally, European leaders must address public resentment towards the political establishment, which continues to fuel the rise of the far-right. Continental peace and stability and cooperation and engagement with the wider world should guide Europe while it reimagines its role in the emerging world order.

The Constitution of India, while federal in structure, was designed with a pronounced centralising bias. Drawing heavily from the Government of India Act, 1935, it concentrated significant authority in New Delhi while assigning a comparatively modest sphere to the States. This architecture was shaped by the circumstances of its birth – the trauma of Partition, the integration of 14 provinces and over 500 princely States, and the pervasive fear that centrifugal forces might threaten national unity. In that climate, centralisation appeared not merely prudent but also indispensable.

Yet, even in those anxious deliberations, there were voices of rare clarity. K. Santhanam cautioned the Constituent Assembly that the Union’s strength lies not in the indiscriminate accumulation of functions, but in the disciplined refusal of responsibilities that do not properly belong at the national level. “It is in this positive as well as negative delimitation of powers that a real federal system rests....” he observed.

In that single formulation lay two enduring principles: first, authority is most effective when exercised closest to knowledge and accountability; and second, excessive centralisation breeds fragility by overburdening a single authority with tasks that it cannot efficiently discharge. A government that attempts to supervise everything – from space exploration to rural sanitation – may expand in reach but this inevitably diminishes its effectiveness.

Reinforcement of dominance

History demonstrates that power assumed in the name of necessity rarely retreats when necessity fades. In the decades that followed, centralising tendencies were reinforced by the dominance of a single national party at the Union and State levels, fostering a “high command” culture that attenuated the autonomy of State leadership. Later, the emergence of coalition governments at the Union and the rise of regional parties in States led to a more balanced federal order without endangering unity. One may reasonably surmise that had today’s politically mature and linguistically consolidated States existed in 1950, the constitutional design might have evolved along a more decentralised path.

Just as an individual cannot remain perpetually captive to the neuroses of childhood, so too a nation cannot forever labour under the anxieties of its formative years. India’s unity is no longer fragile, and the idea of India now rests on firm and enduring foundations. Yet, 76 years later, constitutional practice continues to reflect the reflexes of the late 1940s. Centralisation, once defended as a necessity, has hardened into habit.

Through successive constitutional amendments, expansive Union legislation in Concurrent List subjects, conditional Finance Commission transfers, and centrally sponsored schemes with rigid templates, the balance of power has tilted even further toward the Union. Large ministries exist in New Delhi that duplicate



M.K. Stalin

is the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu

There is a need for balanced federalism in the form of autonomous States, an efficient Union, and accountable governance

State functions and often attempt to steer State priorities through micromanagement and procedural oversight. In an inversion of democratic hierarchy, the Union Executive is attempting to override plenary State laws in Concurrent List subjects through subordinate legislation.

It is a principle

Such a drift sits uneasily with constitutional doctrine. In *S.R. Bommai vs Union of India* (1994), the Supreme Court of India declared federalism part of the Constitution’s Basic Structure and affirmed that States are not mere appendages of the Centre but are supreme within their allotted spheres. Federalism, the Court held, is a principle rooted in India’s history and diversity; not a matter of administrative convenience. Despite this judicial affirmation, State autonomy has continued to erode – through legislative expansion, executive overreach, and certain other judicial interpretations that privilege uniform national solutions over contextual diversity.

Underlying this trajectory is a persistent illusion – that the Union becomes stronger by diminishing the States. In truth, the Union and the States are not competitors in a zero-sum contest; they are partners in a shared constitutional enterprise. India’s size and heterogeneity render centralised policy design inherently limited. No authority in New Delhi, however enlightened, can tailor policy with equal sensitivity to every linguistic region, agricultural ecology, industrial cluster, or labour market.

Decentralisation addresses this limitation by enabling parallel experimentation. States can design and test policies at manageable scale, contain failures without national disruption, and allow successful innovations to diffuse horizontally or be adopted nationally. Many of India’s most effective programmes followed precisely this path. Tamil Nadu’s noon meal scheme, Kerala’s achievements in public health and literacy, and Maharashtra’s employment guarantee initiative all began as State experiments before informing national policy. Over-centralisation suppresses the very diversity of strategies from which innovation and discovery arise.

Centralists often argue that States lack administrative or technical capacity and, therefore, require Union intervention. Yet, such intervention stunts the very capacity it claims to remedy, creating a self-perpetuating cycle of dependence. Parents who do not entrust their children with responsibility, and leaders who refuse to delegate authority, inevitably breed dependence. Governments are no exception.

Capacity arises from responsibility, accountability, and the freedom to make, and correct, mistakes. To suggest that India’s States – many comparable in scale to sovereign nations – are inherently incapable and must, therefore, be subjected to intrusive central control is incompatible with national self-respect.

A budgetary signal as banks cannot bear it all

Budget 2026 has initiated, albeit limited, some important shifts in India’s approach to financial-sector reform. There are proposals to introduce a market-making framework for corporate bonds, develop total-return swaps and bond-index derivatives, establish an Infrastructure Risk Guarantee Fund, and recycle Central Public Sector Enterprises (CPSE) real estate assets through dedicated Real Estate Investment Trusts (REIT). But all these reflect an implicit recognition of a deeper structural problem: Indian banks are shouldering risks that functioning markets absorb elsewhere

Overburdened balance sheets

When Indian banks struggle, weak governance, political interference, and poor risk management are the usual explanations. Each contains some truth. Taken together, however, they miss the larger issue. Over time, India has asked its banks to bear risks that, in more mature systems, are priced, traded, and distributed through markets. This has quietly overburdened bank balance sheets and made the financial system more fragile than it needs to be.

The problem begins with a structural imbalance. India has built a reasonably deep government bond market, supported by the Reserve Bank of India and a predictable issuance framework. Government securities outstanding are close to 90% of GDP, comparable to many large economies. The same cannot be said of corporate bonds. At around 15%-16% of GDP, India’s corporate bond market is less than half the size of China’s and barely a quarter of that in the United States or Germany.

This gap matters because economies do not stop needing long-term finance simply because markets are missing. When bond markets are shallow, someone else must step in. In India, that “someone” has been banks.

Today, banks carry roughly 60%-65% of all non-financial corporate debt, compared with

long timelines, and uncertainties — including technology, human resources, and geopolitical risks — economic returns are unlikely to attract industrial giants. While liability concerns dominate discussion, analysis should

also consider whether prestige in high-end technology is enough incentive to mobilise the enormous investment needed. Criticism due to understandable concerns on nuclear liability should be supplemented by

economic viability analysis and associated information to present the full picture.

N. Ramamoorthy,
Mysuru

In Colombo

With a combination of explosive batting and

ownership is concentrated among a narrow set of institutional investors, and secondary market liquidity is weak. Households and foreign investors play only a marginal role, and issuance is heavily skewed toward top-rated firms. With such limited depth and participation, the bond market cannot meaningfully absorb or price credit risk.

The concentration of risk in the balance sheets of banks also weakens monetary policy transmission. When interest rates rise, banks already burdened with long-term credit exposures are reluctant to pass on higher costs fully; when rates fall, impaired balance sheets constrain fresh lending. The uneven adjustment of long-term borrowing costs despite changes in policy rates reflects this distortion. In contrast, deep bond markets transmit policy signals more smoothly as yields replace across maturities and portfolios rebalance.

No corporate debt market

The core issue stems from the absence of a corporate debt market that can effectively distribute long-term credit risk. Without a deep bond market to distribute exposure across institutional and long-term investors, credit risk remains concentrated on bank balance sheets.

Thus, the measures announced in Budget 2026 are an attempt to correct a long-standing structural imbalance. By improving corporate bond market liquidity, introducing hedging instruments such as total-return swaps, providing partial credit guarantees through the Infrastructure Risk Guarantee Fund, and expanding the stock of market-ready assets through REITs, the Budget gestures towards reallocating risks away from banks and into markets. Whether this shift gathers momentum will determine whether India’s financial system becomes more resilient or continues to rely on banks as the economy’s shock absorber of last resort.

the shooting” — a phrase George Orwell coined in 1945 to criticise excessive nationalism in sports?

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Transitioning to green steel

India's path to net-zero emissions by 2070 will depend heavily on how quickly it scales production and consumption of green steel, as steel remains one of India's largest industrial sources of emissions. The materials we use to build our future must strengthen our progress, not undermine it.

With this in mind, the Ministry of Steel constituted 14 task forces bringing together industry leaders and technical experts to systematically map the sector's decarbonisation levers. Their work covered the full spectrum of transition pathways, which helped create a roadmap for accelerating low-carbon steel production.

But many members saw a barrier: the "green premium." Producing green steel carries high upfront costs for manufacturers. Bridging this gap requires targeted fiscal support for producers in the early years. GST rationalisation and time-bound fiscal incentives can help producers manage the transition. Does this mean that using public procurement to boost demand for premium green steel is an unworkable strategy?

A manageable increment

It is important to distinguish between the producer's additional cost and the actual burden on public procurement. Our analysis showed that even when green steel carries a premium, the effect on large infrastructure projects is minimal. Steel typically accounts for about 18% of large infrastructure projects, which form the bulk of public sector capex in India. As a result, even a 30% premium on green steel, and exclusive use of green steel by public sector infrastructure, translates into an increase of roughly 5.5 % in overall project costs. As not all public infrastructure projects will switch to green steel in the medium term, assuming a 20% rise only results in a 1.1% rise in the budgets of public works such as highways.

This is a manageable increment, especially when seen



Nagendra Nath Sinha
Former Secretary, Ministry of Steel



Alfahad Sorathia
Policy analyst

India possesses a clear opportunity: the technology exists, the green premium is manageable, and the market is ready

as insurance for national economic security. India faces dual pressures from the EU Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism and volatile prices of coking coal imports, which exceed 50 million tonnes annually and expose us to price shocks that affect trade balance and industrial stability. Transitioning to green steel helps bypass carbon tariffs while insulating national projects from fossil fuel price volatility.

Global experience offers a clear template for aligning policy with market reality. Japan's Green Purchasing framework shows that green procurement must work alongside fiscal incentives, pairing demand mandates with production support so industry can respond at scale. California's Buy Clean model highlights how strict carbon benchmarks and verified disclosures create traceability and reduce administrative risk. Building on these lessons, India has introduced a dedicated Green Steel Taxonomy with a 3-, 4-, and 5-star rating system that ranks steel by emission intensity, providing the carbon "nutrition label" the market lacked.

Building on the taxonomy and stakeholder consultations, the Ministry undertook initial steps to institutionalise green steel public procurement mandates. However, the proposal awaits final approval from key stakeholders, including the Ministry of Finance, largely due to concerns around the green premium and verifiability.

The way forward

At the heart of this delay is a trust deficit. Today, a procurement officer has no reliable way to distinguish a certified green TMT bar from a conventional one. Addressing this challenge is possible. By leveraging the existing Made in India QR code infrastructure alongside the Quality Council of India's accreditation system, Green Star ratings could be embedded into product verification. This would allow procurement officers to

instantly confirm the carbon credentials of a product.

Other administrative hurdles can be addressed through targeted reform. For example, procurement frameworks should shift the focus from the lowest upfront price to a broader definition of value for money that recognises sustainability and national economic interest. In parallel, the Schedule of Rates, which guides public works estimates, must explicitly include certified low-carbon steel. Today, green steel may be treated as a deviation because carbon intensity is not recognised as a standard quality parameter. Codifying it would enable officers to procure sustainable materials without administrative risk. Building the capacities of the procurement official, handholding them and evangelising the need for GPP with the States are critical.

Second, our Production Linked Incentives and green hydrogen missions must be aligned with procurement tenders. If the state is subsidising the production of green steel, it must also act as the anchor customer for that output. This alignment ensures that private incentives are harmonised with the public for good.

While a 3-star benchmark provides a practical starting point for adoption, procurement policy should also clearly signal a shift towards 4- and 5-star steel over time. A roadmap that progressively tightens standards after 2030 would encourage industry to invest in higher-grade low-carbon production.

India possesses a window of opportunity: the technology exists, the green premium is manageable, and the market is ready. A practical strategy is to launch focused pilots through centralised purchasers such as the Indian Railways. The procurement scale can create a living lab for green steel. Now, the Ministries of Steel, Finance, and Environment must coordinate to link climate ambition with financial and procurement power.

Inclusive politics in an age of division

Voting is not only about endorsing ideas; it is also about ensuring representation

STATE OF PLAY

Peerzada Ashiq
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Of late, polarising narratives have dominated headlines from Jammu and Kashmir (J&K). Last month, the National Medical Commission withdrew the MBBS course from the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Institute of Medical Excellence in Jammu after protests erupted over the fact that a majority of the students who qualified through NEET were Muslim rather than Hindu. Last week, BJP MLA Vikram Randhawa described residents from the Kashmir Valley as "land grabbers" who had illegally occupied land in Jammu. Students have hit the streets demanding that the National Law University be established in Jammu rather than Kashmir.

Amid this din, however, the stories of Aga Syed Ruhullah Mehdi and Shammi Oberio – both National Conference (NC) parliamentarians – provide a glimpse into a less-discussed story – that of J&K's inclusive politics.

For the first time since the 1990s, none of the Abdullahs, who have long administered J&K, managed to make it to either House of Parliament in the 2024 general elections. There were also other notable changes during the elections. Shammi Oberoi, an eloquent Sikh from Srinagar, became the first from the community from the Kashmir Valley to enter the Rajya Sabha, in 2025. His two speeches in Parliament have won him accolades even from Opposition leaders in Kashmir, a rare gesture in present-day politics.

In the 2024 elections, Syed Aga Ruhullah Mehdi, a Shia cleric from an influential fami-

ly, also became the first from the community to win parliamentary elections by a huge margin of 1.88 lakh votes. Earlier too, Shia leaders from Kashmir have represented the community, but only in the Rajya Sabha. Notably, it was a majority of Sunni Muslim votes that catapulted Mr. Mehdi to the position, enabling him to represent the Kashmir Valley against the backdrop of the dilution of Article 370 and the downgrading of J&K into a Union Territory in 2019.

Mian Altaf Ahmed Larvi became the first Gujar leader from J&K in the Lok Sabha. The only region left unrepresented was the Chenab Valley. But with Sajjad Ahmad Kichloo from Kishtwar winning the Rajya Sabha elections, that gap was filled too.

Representation was the defining feature of the 2024 Assembly elections as well. The numerically upscaled 90-member J&K Assembly went to the polls after a decade. It was a moment for all the political parties to seize. The JKNC won 42 seats – 35 from the Kashmir Valley and seven from the Pir Panjal and Chenab Valleys, including two Hindu representatives. None came from the Jammu plains.

During the process of government formation, the NC's strength rose to 54 with the support of Independents and the Congress (6 seats each). However, it was not numbers alone that defined gover-

nance. In a careful balancing act, the region's smallest-ever Cabinet of six members comprise Chief Minister Omar Abdullah from Central Kashmir; Sakeena Itto from South Kashmir; Javid Ahmad Dar from North Kashmir; Javed Rana, a Pahari from Poonch in the Pir Panjal Valley; Satish Sharma from Jammu's Chhamb; and Surinder Kumar Choudhary from the Pir Panjal Valley.

There were many firsts. Mr. Choudhary became the first Hindu Deputy Chief Minister from the Pir Panjal Valley and also the first without a coalition government in place. In the past, J&K had Hindu Deputy Chief Ministers only when political parties allied with either the Congress or the BJP. If not for numerical necessity, it was the compulsion of inclusive politics that led the government to allocate two Cabinet berths to the Pir Panjal Valley. Jammu would have been excluded from this model had Mr. Sharma not been inducted. He became the first Independent MLA to serve as Cabinet Minister.

The Peace of Westphalia in 1648 helped define the architecture of the modern nation-state and the idea of sovereign geography. Yet beyond sovereignty, the treaties also underscored the principles of balance of power and collective security – ideas that continue to shape democratic systems.

In modern democracies, voting is not merely about endorsing or opposing a political idea; it is also about ensuring that diverse communities and regions find representation within that sovereign framework. At a time when exclusionary politics is gaining ground everywhere, J&K's political landscape serves as a reminder that inclusion is central to the legitimacy of governance.

Can India overtake Bangladesh in EU textile exports?

As Bangladesh prepares to lose its Least Developed Country trade advantage, India's new EU deal could help level the tariff playing field in the sector

DATA POINT

Anwesha Basu
Arnab Chakrabarti

India's textile sector has been steadily losing ground in global export markets. In contrast, Bangladesh has woven together a remarkable export success. Given the recently signed India-EU Free Trade Agreement (FTA), and with Bangladesh poised to lose its Least Developed Country (LDC) status, this is an opportune moment for India's textile industry.

Within the textile value chain, India's exports to the EU remain concentrated in intermediate products – particularly yarns and fabrics – rather than in finished garments such as T-shirts, shirts, and trousers. Bangladesh's exports far exceed India's in two readymade garment categories in particular – knitted or crocheted garments (such as T-shirts, jerseys, pullovers, sweaters, and cardigans) and woven garments (such as suits, jackets, trousers, dresses, and shirts). For knitted/crocheted garments, India's share of the EU's total imports declined from nearly 6.5% in 2009 to about 4.4% in 2023 (**Chart 1A**). Bangladesh's share rose from just 6% in 2000 to 13% in 2009 and 26% by 2023.

A similar pattern is seen in the woven garments trade too (**Chart 1B**). For woven garments, India's nominal export value to the EU fell in absolute numbers from a peak of about \$3.5 billion to \$2.9 billion.

To understand why Indian garments have not been able to compete with Bangladesh in the EU market, we compared the average per-unit price of Bangladesh's major export commodities. From **Table 2**, it is clear that India's unit values are consistently higher across all products. This may indicate the following: First, India may be exporting more value-added, better-quality garments, which allows it to charge higher prices. However,

its low market share reveals that the EU's demand for such products is limited relative to mass-market apparel, suggesting that 'premium positioning' (if at all) alone cannot drive volume. Second, and more likely, is that higher prices may reflect structural disadvantages: higher production costs, less integrated supply chains and logistical inefficiencies.

Furthermore, the tariffs faced by Indian and Bangladeshi products are radically different (**Chart 3**). Bangladesh, as a LDC, has enjoyed duty-free, quota-free access to the EU under the Everything But Arms (EBA) scheme. Crucially, this zero-tariff access applies even when garments do not meet the EU's standard 'double transformation' requirement. This means Bangladesh can import fabric from anywhere in the world, stitch garments domestically, and export them to the EU at zero duty. India, lacking such preferential treatment, has faced EU Most Favoured Nation (MFN) tariffs of around 12%.

Internal factors also matter. Over the past three decades, Bangladesh has unilaterally and consistently promoted the garment sector. India's approach, by contrast, has been fragmented. Yet, the balance may be poised to shift. Two major structural breaks are on the horizon.

First, Bangladesh is set to lose its EBA benefits in 2029. This would mean the end of automatic duty-free access to the EU, with apparel exports potentially facing MFN tariffs of around 12%. Bangladesh is then expected to seek entry into the EU's Generalised Scheme of Preferences Plus (GSP+), which offers zero tariffs on roughly two-thirds of tariff lines, including textiles. However, GSP+ comes with stricter rules of origin (RoO) and safeguard provisions. As Bangladesh is heavily reliant on other countries (including India) for fabrics, this could mean that Bangladesh's garments may not satisfy GSP+ RoO for duty free entry. Bangladesh, will of course, try its

best to negotiate its way out of this clause. Historically, EU has maintained its stance on the double transformation criteria. In case it continues to do so, Bangladesh will be at a serious disadvantage. If competition is price-driven, then Bangladesh may lose its market share. If, on the other hand, Bangladesh's primary advantage comes from supply-chain integration, then it could still retain dominance in the face of higher tariffs.

The recently finalised agreement grants India duty-free access to the EU's textile markets, subject to the double-stage processing requirement. Since India's textile industry is already relatively vertically integrated – most of the yarn and fabric used in apparel production is manufactured domestically – the double-stage requirement is not likely to be an impediment for Indian textile exports. As a result, Indian exporters are well-positioned to meet stricter rules of origin without major restructuring.

Taken together, these changes create a rare window of opportunity: narrowing of Bangladesh's preferential advantage and reduction of India's tariff disadvantage. Textiles remain one of the largest employers in Indian manufacturing, spanning both formal and informal enterprises, yet the sector has failed to create employment opportunities in recent years. Reviving textile exports, particularly to high-income markets like the EU, could act as a much-needed tonic for India's employment crisis. The question is whether India is finally ready to tailor a strategy that fits, capturing market share with cost-competitive production, vertical integration, and a coherent industrial policy. The recent experience of Vietnam's apparel exports, which saw a surge post the signing of the EU-Vietnam FTA in 2020, is indicative of the opportunities on the horizon for India.

Anwesha Basu and Arnab Chakrabarti are Assistant Professors in the Department of Economics, FLAME University

A looming shift?

The data for the charts were sourced from the World Integrated Trade Solution by the World Bank



CHARTS 1A & 1B: India's and Bangladesh's shares in the EU's import basket for knitted/crocheted garments (1A) and woven garments (1B) (in %)

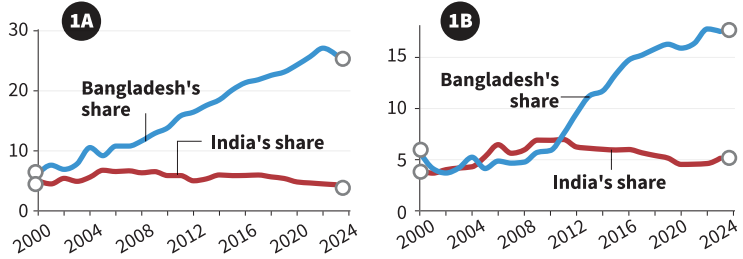
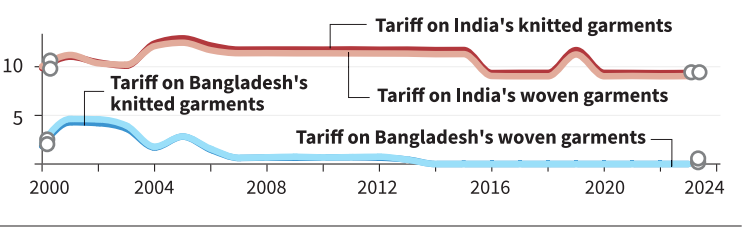


TABLE 2: Unit value comparisons of major export commodities (in \$ per unit)

Commodities	Year	Bangladesh	India
T-shirts (knitted/crocheted)	2023	2.6	3.35
T-shirts (knitted/crocheted)	2024	2.4	2.9
Jerseys (knitted/crocheted)	2023	6.4	7.5
Jerseys (knitted/crocheted)	2024	6.02	6.3
Men's suits, jackets, trousers (woven)	2023	9	13.4
Men's suits, jackets, trousers (woven)	2024	9.2	12.5
Women's suits, jackets, dresses (woven)	2023	7.5	9.5
Women's suits, jackets, dresses (woven)	2024	7.5	9.6
Men's shirts (woven)	2023	7.5	10.4
Men's shirts (woven)	2024	7.4	10.14

CHART 3: Tariffs (in %) imposed by the EU on India and Bangladesh for garments



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu.**

FIFTY YEARS AGO FEBRUARY 17, 1976

Campaign in China initiated by Mao

Hong Kong, Feb. 16: China's current political struggle, which appears to be spearheaded against the Vice-Premier, Mr. Teng Hsiao-ping was "personally initiated" by the Communist Party Chairman, Mr. Mao Tse-tung, Shanghai Radio reported to-day.

The campaign began as a debate over education policies. Recently it has turned into a vehement attack on leaders purged during the Cultural Revolution and who have been restored to power but have refused to make proper penance.

Mr. Teng, host to the U.S. President, Mr. Gerald Ford, during his December visit to Peking, is the most prominent leader in this category.

The Shanghai broadcast reported that a mass rally was held in China's largest city last Friday under the sponsorship of the Shanghai Revolutionary Committee. About 1,800 people attended mainly committee cadres and officials of scientific and technological institutes in the city.

That rally was believed to be one of the first – if not the first – mass meetings not confined to a college campus since the criticism heated up against Mr. Teng.

The broadcast said the current struggle against the "right deviationist wind" was significant. In addition to denouncing alleged attempts by rehabilitated persons such as Mr. Teng, to restore other Cultural Revolution victims to power, it also attacked the economic policies they are pushing.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO FEBRUARY 17, 1926

League's anti-malaria campaign

Rugby, Feb. 16: The Health Organisation of the League of Nations has arranged to hold next summer in London, Paris and Hamburg, special laboratory courses on malaria, which will be reserved exclusively for medical officers. During its tours of the Eastern and Southern Europe, the League's Malaria Commission discovered that several countries were prevented from conducting systematic anti-malaria campaign owing to the shortage of specially trained physicians.

From Page One

NGT clears ₹92,000-cr. Great Nicobar project

The NGT Bench, headed by its Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava, noted that it found no error in the drafting of the terms of reference for the HPC, adding that the applicants did not point out “any other substantial issue” that should have been examined by the HPC.

Further, noting the Union government’s stance against public disclosure of the HPC report, given that it is “of strategic, defence and national importance and has confidential and privileged information”, the NGT said, “The above disclosures reveal that the project is very important for India.”

The NGT order said that to ensure “full and effective” compliance with the EC conditions, the Environment Ministry “will undertake all measures to protect the coral reefs along the coastal stretch and will also ensure coral regeneration through proved scientific method for regeneration”. The NGT asked the Environment Ministry to prepare and approve an “implementation plan” in this regard

‘Responsibility of Environment Ministry’

On erosion of shorelines of the Great Nicobar Island, the NGT said it “will be the responsibility” of the Environment Ministry to “ensure that on account of proposed constructions which includes foreshore development, there is no erosion/shoreline change”. On protecting coral reefs, the Bench relied on the government’s submissions that “no coral reef exists within the work area of the project.”

The applicants had also submitted that the Environmental Impact Assessment for the project was conducted for just one season, as opposed to three seasons as mandated by regulations. On this, the NGT noted the government’s submissions that “since there is no high erosion site in Andaman & Nicobar, therefore, three-season data is not required”.

While the project’s environmental clearance was under challenge before the NGT, aspects of the project’s forest clearance are currently under challenge before the Calcutta High Court. Apart from the alarm raised by conservationists and activists about the project’s potential damage to the ecology , locals on the island have objected to the project’s approval, alleging that their consent for it had not been taken lawfully. The locals – the Nicobarese and the Shompen – have alleged that their rights on forest lands which are supposed to be used for the project had not been settled.

India’s AI summit opens to massive crowds

The summit featured over 100 events, excluding those that were not livestreamed. In the exhibition hall, over 400 booths were active, spanning industry, academia, startups, and tech giants.

Logistical challenges

However, the event was not without hitches – many attendees complained online about overcrowding, long queues at food courts, where some vendors refused digital payments. In the afternoon, parts of the venue were cleared for security sanitisation, leading to exhibitors being asked to vacate at short notice. One exhibitor complained that wearable devices on display were stolen. Access to several areas was also restricted later in the day, resulting in long queues.

There were, however, some novel arrangements. A quick-commerce platform set up grocery and snack drop-off points across Bharat Mandapam, while an online food ordering and delivery company facilitated food deliveries. Digi Yatra was at entry gates, enabling attendees to use facial recognition for automated access.

Mr. Modi is scheduled to address the plenary session on Thursday, when the event will be closed to general visitors.

SC to review if data law delivers a ‘blow’ to RTI

Mr. Bhushan argued that a five-judge Constitution Bench in its November 2019 judgment in *Central Public Information Officer versus Supreme Court of India* had examined Section 8(I)(j) of the RTI Act to apply the proportionality test to balance the right to information against the right to privacy. The 2019 judgment held that personal information should remain in the realm of privacy unless disclosure was necessary in the larger public interest.

“It is an unreasonable restriction on the right under Article 19. Privacy is not a fundamental right available to the State. It violates Article 14 by equating the privacy of public functionaries to that of ordinary citizens. It inverts the jurisprudence of privacy vis-à-vis the right to information and prioritises privacy over the larger public interest of transparency and open governance,” Mr. Nayak’s petition argued.

Mr. Bhushan said the consequence of the DPDP provision was both immediate and serious. “Every RTI application involving identifiable public officials, procurement records, audit reports, appointment files, utilisation of public funds, or exercise of statutory discretion can now be denied automatically on the ground that it ‘relates to personal information’,” Mr. Bhushan submitted.

The petitioners contended that the amendment to Section 8(I)(j) of the RTI Act has rendered the “right to information illusory”.

SC dismisses pleas against Himanta’s ‘hate speech’, video

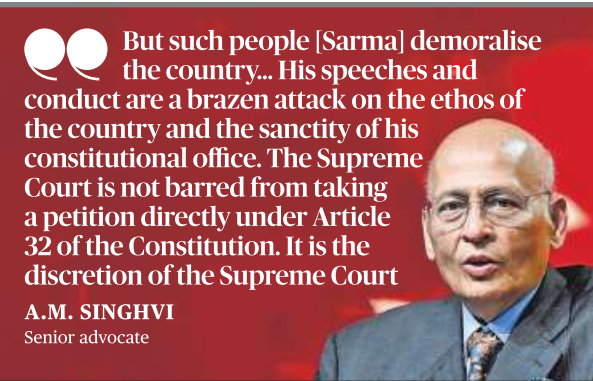
A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India asks petitioners to approach the Gauhati High Court despite petitioners pointing out that the head of the Assam government is indulging in hate speech

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday found “no good reason” to entertain a series of petitions seeking a criminal investigation against Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma for giving communal speeches and for a social media post, since deleted, depicting him firing a gun towards an animated image of two Muslim men.

Instead, a three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant asked the petitioners, including the Communist Party of India (Marxist) and the Communist Party of India, to approach the Gauhati High Court despite the petitioners pointing out that Mr. Sarma is the “boss of Assam”.

The Supreme Court declined to entertain the petition, though it agreed with the petitioners that no political leader or constitu-



tional officeholder should conduct themselves in a manner that harms the secular ethos enshrined in the Constitution.

The petitioner-parties have accused Mr. Sarma of indulging in a “sustained pattern of hate speeches”. They said the social media post, from the “official handle of the Bharatiya Janata Party, Assam on X, and thereafter widely disseminated, has been the most blatant and disturbing manifestation of the pattern complained of”.

The petition said that

the video was removed from the public domain following severe backlash. However, the material continued to be circulated through other platforms.

The petitioners, led by senior advocates A.M. Singhvi and C.U. Singh and advocate Nizam Pasha, submitted that Mr. Sarma, while holding the office of the Chief Minister of Assam, gave speeches which “target, terrorise, and instigate hostility and overt violence against the Muslim community residing in Assam”.

Centre silent on Pannun case; officials await U.S. court documents after Gupta pleads guilty

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

Three days after Indian citizen Nikhil Gupta pleaded “guilty” in a court in New York to charges of murder, conspiracy, and money laundering in order to assassinate Khalistani activist Gurpatwant Singh Pannun, the government has yet to comment on the case.

According to investigators in the United States, Mr. Gupta, an Indian businessman, worked with an Indian “government employee” Vikash Yadav, believed to have been associated with India’s Research and Analysis Wing (RAW), to hire a hitman to carry out Pannun’s murder for a sum of \$100,000. Mr. Yadav, who was arrested in December 2023 in Delhi in a separate case of kidnapping and extortion, has been out on bail since April 2024, and is



Indian national Nikhil Gupta being extradited to the United States, from Prague, Czech Republic in June 2024. PTI

expected to appear for his next hearing later this week on February 20, according to his lawyers.

In court last Friday, Mr. Gupta, who had thus far pleaded “not guilty”, made an unexpected appearance, and pleaded guilty to the three counts – murder-for-hire, conspiracy to commit murder-for-hire, and conspiracy to commit money laundering.

The External Affairs Ministry refused to comment on the developments in the New York court.

Gupta’s consular access

Officials indicated that they would await court documents, and confirmed that the Indian Consulate-General in New York had been granted consular access to Mr. Gupta, an Indian citizen, and were prepared to

assist him with any consular requirements.

In his pleadings, Mr. Gupta told the judge in the Southern District of New York court that in 2023 he “agreed with another person” to murder a person in the U.S., and delivered \$15,000 as an advance for the job. Mr. Gupta will face the court again on May 29 for sentencing. It is unclear, however, whether he has confessed his guilt in lieu of a lesser sentence as part of a larger agreement with the U.S. Attorney’s office, which would involve his cooperation in the investigation or as an “approver”.

“The FBI will continue to aggressively defend the homeland against any foreign adversaries who target our citizens for exercising their constitutionally protected rights,” FBI Assistant Director in-charge James Barnacle said in a statement after the guilty

EC suspends seven Bengal officials for ‘serious misconduct’

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

The Election Commission (EC) exercised its powers under electoral laws to suspend seven officials from West Bengal over “serious misconduct” related to the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the State.

All seven officials are State government employees assigned to work for the SIR process.

Disciplinary action

In a letter dated February 15, Sujeet Kumar Mishra, Secretary, EC, wrote to the Chief Secretary of West Bengal, Nandini Chakraborty, asking that disciplinary proceedings be initiated against the seven officials.

“... Suspension with immediate effect for serious misconduct, dereliction of duty and misuse of statutory powers in connection with SIR,” the letter from EC stated.

Disciplinary proceedings should be initiated im-

All seven officials are State government employees assigned to work for the SIR process

mediately, and the EC kept informed, the letter said.

EC directives

On February 13, Ms. Chakraborty was summoned by the EC and asked to comply with all pending directives from the poll body, including payment of remuneration to booth-level officers, and the filing of formal complaints against on-duty officers flagged for misconduct. Ms. Chakraborty was given time till February 17 to comply.

Manoj Pant, Ms. Chakraborty’s predecessor, was also rapped by the EC for similar reasons.

Since the start of the SIR process, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and officials of her government have been at loggerheads with the EC.

J&K plans to harness river waters as IWT is in abeyance

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

The Jammu & Kashmir government is mulling to take advantage of the suspended Indus Waters Treaty (IWT) by diverting, for the first time, water from the Ravi river in Punjab to the Jammu region, and push for the revival of the Tulbul Navigation Barrage project in the Kashmir region.

Sources said Chief Minister Omar Abdullah has raised the issue with the Centre. The Tulbul project hit a dead end when Pakistan raised objections in 1987. However, the Centre put the treaty in abeyance after the Pahalgam attack.

The government has made a proposal to enable year-round navigation on the Wular lake by maintaining a minimum depth of water, which was not possible because of the treaty.

Two Pakistan nationals escape from juvenile home

The Hindu Bureau
JAMMU

Three jail inmates, including two Pakistani nationals, allegedly escaped from a juvenile home in Jammu’s R.S. Pura on Monday.

The police identified the escapees as Karajeet Singh, a resident of Dablehar R.S. Pura, and Mohd Suna-ullah and Ahsan Anwar, both Pakistani nationals.

Initial reports suggested they escaped occurred around 5.15 p.m. The trio allegedly assaulted the guards on duty and managed to escape from the facility. One of the accused brandished a pistol to threaten the staff of the observation home. “The injured police personnel were provided medical assistance,” an official said.

Officials said special teams were constituted to trace the escaped inmates. Raids were also conducted in multiple areas to find the absconding inmates.

17 tourism destinations that were closed after Pahalgam attack reopened in J&K

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha on Monday announced the reopening of 17 tourist destinations, which were closed after the Pahalgam attack 10 months ago.

“After a thorough security review and discussion, Mr. Sinha has ordered the reopening of more tourist spots in Kashmir and Jammu divisions, which were temporarily closed as a precautionary measure,” a Lok Bhavan spokesperson said.

The destinations reopened in the Kashmir Valley included Yousmarg, Doodhpathri, Dandipora Park, Peer Ki Gali, Dubjan, Padpawan, Astanpora, Tulip Garden, Thajiwas Glacier, Hung Park, and Wular-Watlab.

“Three sites in the Kashmir division (Gurez and



The reopened sites include the Tulip Garden in Srinagar.

Athwatoo in Bandipora and Bangus in Kupwara) and Ramkund in Ramban in the Jammu division will be reopened once snow gets cleared,” the spokesperson said.

The three tourist spots reopened in the Jammu division are Devi Pindi, Mahu Mangat and Mughal Maidan.

Forty-eight destinations were closed in the wake of the Pahalgam terror attack that left 26 civilians dead

on April 22, 2025. On June 14, 2025, 16 destinations were reopened to tourists.

The closure of the destinations heavily impacted winter tourism in Kashmir. Hundreds of local people dependent on tourism lost their livelihood.

In the Jammu division, Lieutenant-General P.K. Mishra, General Officer Commanding of the Army’s White Knight Corps, on Monday toured Kishtwar district in the Chenab Valley and reviewed the counter-terrorism grid and operational preparedness of the troops.

“The GOC, accompanied by GOC Cif (Delta), visited the general area of Kishtwar, J-K, to review the counter-terrorism grid and assess the operational preparedness of deployed units,” the White Knight Corps said on X.

He was briefed on the prevailing security situation.

BJP ignoring injustice faced by gig workers, says Rahul Gandhi

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, on Monday, alleged that the Union government and BJP-ruled States were turning a blind eye to the injustices faced by gig workers.

Class and caste-based discrimination were deeply embedded in the sector, and there was little accountability for companies, Mr. Gandhi said.

The Congress leader recently interacted with a delegation of gig workers at a ‘Jan Sansad’ – a meeting he holds with groups in the Parliament complex.

In a post on Facebook, Mr. Gandhi said the discussions showed the need for strong government action to ensure workers benefited from the gig economy.

“Today, gig workers lack stable income, social security, or basic amenities like medical care and insu-



Rahul Gandhi

rance. Work-life balance is disrupted, and basic human dignity is being eroded,” Mr. Gandhi said. Women gig workers faced “double exploitation”, combining economic insecurity with a lack of safety and respect, he alleged.

Accusing the BJP of inaction, he said governments at the Centre and in States had failed to enact strong laws or provide social security for gig workers.

Congress-ruled States were working on rights-based frameworks to ensure social security and equal treatment for gig workers, he said.

Assam Cong. leader rethinks resignation from party

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Causing a flutter in poll-bound Assam, former State Congress president Bhupen Kumar Borah announced resignation from the party on Monday, but later sought time to think the decision over.

Mr. Borah made it apparent that he was unhappy with the State leadership of the party. “I have apprised the central leadership that the future of the party will be uncertain if it is led this way. Everyone, including our alliance partners, knows what is happening in the party and how it is being led,” Mr. Borah said.

Senior leaders rushed to Mr. Borah’s Guwahati residence following the announcement to try and convince him to withdraw his resignation. “My old colleagues and central leaders have given certain suggestions. However, I have sought some time,” Mr. Borah told journalists, adding that he would go by what his family advises and let the leadership know by Tuesday morning. The Congress’s Assam in-charge, Jitendra Singh, however, indicated that Mr. Borah withdrew his resignation after senior leader Rahul Gandhi spoke to him for about 15 minutes.

Global platforms must respect local culture and laws: Vaishnaw

Union Minister, at the AI Impact Summit, says there are no ‘physical boundaries’ in the digital world, but acceptability differs within societies; govt. initiatives will generate more opportunities for global media industry to ‘create in India’, he says

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Global content-making platforms must be aware of the cultural context of the countries in which they operate and work according to the constitutional and legal frameworks there, Union Minister of Electronics and Information Technology, Ashwini Vaishnaw, said on Monday.

He was speaking with Charles Rivkin, chairman and CEO of the Motion Picture Association, at an official satellite event of the AI Impact Summit, titled “Rewarding our creative future in the age of AI – strengthening India through innovation, trust and talent”.

The Union Minister said global OTT and digital content platforms must function in accordance with the laws of the host country, rather than those of their parent country.

“In the digital world, there are no physical boundaries. In that scenario, it is very easy for the OTT platforms to forget the cultural context, which is very important. What is normal in one society, may not be



Tech talks: PM Narendra Modi and Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw at the AI Impact Summit in New Delhi on Monday. ANI

normal in another society,” Mr. Vaishnaw told Mr. Rivkin.

The Minister said global platforms such as Motion Picture Association and Netflix must be aware of the “cultural context of the country in which they are operating”.

‘Create in India’

Mr. Vaishnaw said reskilling, upskilling, and new skilling initiatives by the Union government will

Media platforms must function in accordance with the host country’s laws, rather than that of their parent country, the Minister says

create more opportunities for the global media industry to come and create in India.

“Very soon, we will be launching a ‘Create in In-

‘Advance of AI creating a governance responsibility’

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Artificial intelligence is a double-edged sword, and the governance objective should be to sharpen the edge of opportunity while blunting the edge of risk, Ajay Kumar Sood, Principal Scientific Adviser to the Centre, said on Monday. “Digital penetration has increased, and children are increasingly exposed to AI-driven platforms. We

still do not fully know the long-term effects of growing up with AI companions and synthetic media,” he said at a session at the ongoing AI Impact Summit.

“The need to embed child-specific safeguards and guardrails into the governance framework is not a choice, but it is a must,” Mr. Sood said, underlining that the advance of AI has created a governance responsibility.

dia’ mission. Like the semiconductor mission, it will also be very industry-oriented, employment-oriented, and future-oriented mission,” he said.

The Union Minister said that the initiative would make sure that India became the “most-preferred platform of the world for creating” and make available a “future-ready talent pipeline which keeps that growth we need to have for the next 25 years”.

Mr. Vaishnaw also highlighted the “natural inclination” of the country’s large population toward digital technologies. He said people in India were “digitally native” and naturally adapt to new technologies.

Talking about the AI Impact Summit in New Delhi, he said global leadership was gathering in India to deliberate on how to reap the benefits of digital innovation while curbing its disadvantages.

AI Summit important for cooperation to unlock potential: U.K.

Press Trust of India
LONDON

The U.K.’s focus during the AI Impact Summit in New Delhi will be on championing how artificial intelligence can supercharge growth, unlock new jobs, improve public services, and deliver benefits for people around the globe, the British government has said.

The U.K. delegation, led by Deputy Prime Minister David Lammy and AI Minister Kanishka Narayan, is keen to highlight how AI can improve everyday life in every corner of the world and make the case for AI as an engine of renewal that can help doctors diagnose faster, teachers personalise learning, councils deliver services in minutes, and businesses create the next generation of good jobs. “This summit is an important moment in determining how we can work together with our international partners to unlock the full benefits and potential of AI, while baking in robust and fair safety standards that protect us all,” Mr. Lammy said in a pre-summit statement.

“AI is the defining technology of our generation, and we’re determined to make sure it delivers for everyone,” said Mr. Na-



David Lammy

rayan, the first Indian-origin MP from Wales.

“It can cut waiting times, transform public services, create new jobs and give hard-working communities a fresh start - and that’s exactly the message we’re taking to the summit. It is central to our plans for delivering national renewal, but its benefits can’t and shouldn’t be reserved by the few,” he said.

The U.K.’s Department for Science, Innovation and Technology said India and Britain were “natural tech partners”, with software giants such as Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, and Wipro expanding their operations across the U.K.

India is an important market for British businesses generally, with U.K. firms generating more than 47.5 billion pounds in revenue from their business in India, it said.

Modi to meet Macron in Mumbai today, hold talks on strategic ties

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

French President Emmanuel Macron and First Lady Brigitte Macron arrived in Mumbai on Monday night for an official visit to India till February 19.

The French President will meet Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Mumbai on Tuesday, and the two leaders will exchange memoranda of understanding (MoUs) before giving a press statement at the Lok Bhavan here. The meeting will focus on cementing the strategic partnership between the two countries and diversifying it into new and emerging areas. Mr. Modi and Mr. Macron will also exchange views on issues of regional and global importance and will review the progress made in the bilateral strategic partnership.

Elaborate security ar-



Welcome sight: Billboards welcoming French President Emmanuel Macron ahead of his visit to India, seen in Mumbai on Monday. AFP

rangements have been made in the country’s financial capital to host the dignitaries. Mr. Macron will be in Delhi on February 18 and 19 and will attend the ongoing AI Impact Summit.

The French leader will attend several private engagements and meetings in Mumbai, where temporary traffic restrictions have been put in place. This will

likely include a meeting with the film industry. In the evening, Mr. Modi and Mr. Macron will launch the ‘India-France Year of Innovation 2026’ and will address a gathering of business leaders, start-ups, researchers, and other innovators from both countries. They will visit the Gateway of India thereafter for a cultural commemoration programme.

India, France to hold sixth annual defence dialogue today

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and the Minister for Armed Forces and Veterans Affairs of France, Catherine Vautrin, will co-chair the sixth India-France Annual Defence Dialogue in Bengaluru on Tuesday, and review the bilateral defence cooperation with focus on expanding industrial collaboration.

According to the Ministry of Defence, the defence cooperation agreement is expected to be renewed for another 10 years during the meeting.

U.S. trade deal ‘mortgages’ farmer interests, energy security, says Cong.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Accusing Prime Minister Narendra Modi of “surrendering” before the U.S., the Congress on Monday said the India-U.S. interim trade agreement undermines India’s energy security, data and digital autonomy, livelihood of farmers, and economic self-reliance.

The principal Opposition party said it was ready to debate the issue with the ruling party at a place and time of their choice.

“I have been instructed by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi *ji* to place the facts,” party general secretary Randeep Surjewala said addressing a press conference, adding that he was ready to debate with them “in the BJP office even today”.

Mr. Surjewala was responding to the challenge



Congress general secretary Randeep Surjewala, right, addressing a press conference in New Delhi on Monday. ANI

posed by Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday for “Mr. Gandhi to debate the trade deal with the chief of the BJP Yuva Morcha (youth wing)”.

Mr. Surjewala said trade agreements must be based on parity and mutual interest, not at the cost of national sovereignty.

“National interest cannot be mortgaged under the guise of a trade deal,”

he said, describing the agreement as a “one-sided and unequal” pact that compromises India’s core economic priorities.

Mr. Surjewala alleged that the framework agreement of February 6 opened the door to duty-free imports of American agricultural and food products, which he said would “devastate” the livelihoods of crores of farmers across

the country.

Former Commerce and Industry Minister Anand Sharma also criticised the Centre, calling the Prime Minister’s remarks on trade negotiations under the Congress-led UPA government “unfair and incorrect”. He said that during the UPA government, India negotiated trade agreements with ASEAN, Japan, South Korea, Singapore, and Malaysia as a “self-assured nation and a sovereign equal”.

“During the UPA government, India’s economy grew rapidly and registered an average annual GDP growth over 8%. Indian economy withstood the global meltdown following the 2008 banking and financial crash and rebounded quickly,” Mr. Sharma told *The Hindu*, describing the interim trade deal with the U.S. as a “sell-out” deal.

‘Full Manipur Cabinet, Ministers’ portfolio will be decided soon’

Deputy Chief Minister says the rehabilitation of people displaced by the long violence in the State is a priority for the new government; on his colleague Nemcha Kipgen, a Kuki-Zo leader, not being able to travel to Imphal, he says, ‘She is supporting us to reach out to the people’; the State government plans to hold a Cabinet meeting in Senapati, a Naga area, and go there via Kangpokpi, a Kuki-Zo area

INTERVIEW

Losii Dikho

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

On February 4, President’s Rule was revoked in Manipur and a new Chief Minister, Yumnam Khemchand Singh, a Meitei, was sworn in, along with two deputies – Losii Dikho, a Naga, and Nemcha Kipgen, a Kuki-Zo. Mr. Dikho, from the Naga People’s Front, an alliance partner of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), speaks about the priorities of the new government. Edited excerpts:

It has been over 10 days

since the swearing-in ceremony of the Chief Minister and the two Deputy CMs, including you, took place. Why is the full Cabinet not in place and why have portfolios not been allocated yet?

The portfolios will be allocated after the full Cabinet is expanded. I spoke to the Chief Minister, and he agreed with me.

When is it expected?

It should not take much time. And of course, it has to be coordinated with the Centre.

You were the chief guest at a football match organised by the Zomi

Council last week at Churachandpur. What was the outcome?

It was a fruitful trip. The nine tribes under the nomenclature Zomi had organised the event. I had a closed-door meeting with all the tribe leaders, the president, and all of them strongly supported the formation of the government. They invited me again for another festival on February 20.

After the ethnic violence between Meitei and Kuki-Zo people erupted on May 3, 2023, over 60,000 people were displaced from their homes. What is the government’s strategy to rehabilitate them?



This is a priority. Money has been distributed among the people and additional money has been provided to the displaced people who are moving back to their homes.

The Litan area in Ukhrul district has witnessed clashes and arson between the Kuki

and Naga communities over the past two weeks? How is the situation now, and what is the government’s strategy?

The issue is not between all Nagas and Kukis. Few members of Tangkhul Nagas and

Kukis were involved. But we cannot keep silent and we intervened and involved the United Naga Council and the head of the Tangkhul tribe; we joined hands.

The land dispute between the two communities should be settled and the land ownership and agreement has to be worked out. Both communities have come to an understanding and stopped the fight but till now no agreement has been signed. But it is almost under control. Naga people do not want to have these tensions any more, but the landowners have to be recognised

The other Deputy CM, Nemcha Kipgen, a

Kuki-Zo, has not been able to travel to Imphal yet. So how is the government functioning and how are the three of you communicating?

She is at present at her home in Kangpokpi, and every day, we speak on the phone.

She is supporting us to reach out to the people as she cannot come to Imphal. We do virtual video meetings. So far, two Cabinet meetings under the Chief Minister have taken place where she participated through a video call.

What about the free movement of all vehicles and people

from all communities on National Highway-2? It hasn’t started yet.

I have spoken to the Deputy CM and our second plan is that we will have a Cabinet meeting in Senapati (Naga area) next. The CM told her that we will go to Senapati by road via Kangpokpi (Kuki-Zo area, NH-2 passes through here) and that we have to reach out to people. As the new government has been installed, there is a good response from all the communities. I reached out to the Thadou people in Kangpokpi, and they have invited me to attend the church on Sunday. It is a positive sign.

$MCH-CH_2$

Business

INBRIEF



NPCI extends ‘UPI One World’ to AI Summit foreign visitors

National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) has announced the extension of the UPI One World wallet services for international visitors from over 40 countries attending the India AI Impact Summit 2026 from February 16-20 in New Delhi. “Through this pilot initiative, inbound foreign travellers will be able to make seamless, secure, and real-time Person-to-Merchant (P2M) UPI payments during their visit to India,” the NPCI said in a statement.

Unemployment in India rose slightly to 5% in January: Govt.

The rate of unemployment in the country among persons aged 15 years and above rose slightly to 5% in January from 4.8% in December 2025, according to a government survey released on Monday. The unemployment rate recorded a marginal increase in January in both rural and urban areas, showed the latest Periodic Labour Force Survey. The data also showed lower labour force participation rate as well as workers population ratio across rural and urban areas.

IIFL Finance to raise up to ₹2,000 crore through NCDs

IIFL Finance Ltd. has launched public issue of secured listed redeemable non-convertible debentures (NCDs) of face value of ₹1,000 each for an amount up to ₹500 crore (base issue size) with a green shoe option of up to ₹1,500 crore, cumulatively aggregating up to ₹2,000 crore (Tranche I issue limit). The Tranche I issue has 9 series of NCDs carrying fixed coupons on tenure of 24 months, 36 months, and 60 months with annual, monthly and cumulative interest options.

NSE gets SEBI nod for natural gas futures

Lalatendu Mishra
Saptaparno Ghosh
MUMBAI/NEW DELHI

Heralding the institution of a market-based mechanism for price discovery and the availability of natural gas in the country, the National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) said on Monday it had received approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) to launch Indian Natural Gas futures.

The NSE Indian Natural Gas futures would be monthly contracts. Additionally, at any point of time, there would be 12 monthly contracts available for trading.

The exchange also informed that further details on contract designs and launch timelines would be “announced in due course”.

On January 8, NSE had first announced the strategic collaboration with the Indian Gas Exchange (IGX) to develop and set up Indian Natural Gas futures. It would seek to combine NSE’s market infrastructures in the derivatives space and IGX’s mechanism for spot trading of natural gas.

The introduction of the natural gas futures is expected to benefit gas producers, city gas distributors, power generators, fertiliser manufacturers, industrial consumers, traders and financial participants by “enabling effective hedging against price volatility and improving long-term planning”, the NSE said.

January trade deficit widens before U.S. tariff relief kicks in

Sharp rise in gold and silver imports pushed up total imports by 12% month-on-month to \$71.24 bn, while exports fell 5% to \$36.56 bn; trade delegation to visit Washington next week for talks

Reuters
NEW DELHI

India’s merchandise trade deficit widened to a three-month high of \$34.68 billion in January, marking the final month impacted by around 50% U.S. tariff on Indian exports, which government officials said will be pared to 18% this week.

The wider-than-expected goods trade deficit was driven by a sharp rise in gold and silver imports, which pushed up total imports by 12% month-on-month to \$71.24 billion, while exports fell 5% to \$36.56 billion, data from



Goods surge: Shipments to the U.S. rose to \$72.46 billion in the first 10 months of the fiscal year. REUTERS

the commerce ministry showed on Monday.

U.S. President Donald Trump said earlier this month that he would slash tariffs on Indian goods to 18% from 50%, sparking re-

lief among exporters and policymakers.

Mr. Trump said that India had agreed to cut Russian oil purchases and intended to more than double its annual imports

L&T to sell Nabha Power to Torrent Power for ₹3,661 cr.

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

L&T Power Development Ltd. (LTPDL), a wholly owned subsidiary of Larsen & Toubro (L&T), has announced to sell 100% of equity and convertible instruments in Nabha Power Ltd. (NPL) to Torrent Power Ltd., for ₹3,661 crore.

The transaction is subject to requisite regulatory approvals, L&T said in a filing. “Given NPL’s long-term power purchase

The divestment is a value-driven monetisation exercise, the company said

agreement and stable operating performance, the divestment is a value-driven monetisation exercise. The transaction is aligned with L&T’s broader strategy to exit the development projects business,” the company said.

Motilal Oswal Alternates raises ₹8,500 crore

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Motilal Oswal Alternates said it had raised ₹8,500 crore for fifth private equity fund, India Business Excellence Fund V (IBEF V/ Fund V), making it the largest in the firm’s private equity history.

“The fund witnessed strong participation from both global and domestic investors, significantly surpassing its initial fundraising target of ₹6,500 crore

of U.S. goods.

A trade delegation will travel to Washington next week to finalise a trade agreement, Rajesh Agrawal, India’s trade secretary, told reporters on Monday.

The two nations are currently working on a trade pact on the basis of an interim framework, concluded earlier this month.

Merchandise exports to the U.S., India’s largest export market, fell 4.5% month-on-month to \$6.58 billion in January. Shipments to the U.S. rose to \$72.46 billion in the first ten months of the fiscal year, data showed.

MARKETS

MARKET WATCH

	MONDAY	% CHANGE
Sensex	83,277	0.79
US Dollar	90.74	-0.08
Gold	1,59,200	0.44
Brent oil	68.45	—

NIFTY 50

	PRICE	CHANGE
Adani Enter.....	2384.60	-48.00
Adani Ports.....	1540.10	-21.10
Apollo Hosp.....	7618.00	-75.50
Asian Paints.....	2397.20	-30.80
Axis Bank.....	1358.30	-26.00
Bajaj Auto.....	9697.50	-62.50
Bajaj Finserv.....	2050.90	-27.70
Bajaj Finance.....	1012.75	-12.00
Bharat Elec.....	438.00	-2.45
Bharti Airtel.....	2029.40	-24.70
Cipla.....	1356.40	-24.90
Coal India.....	422.50	-13.55
Dr Reddys Lab.....	1269.40	-1.30
Eicher Motors.....	8010.50	-54.50
Eternal Ltd.....	286.60	-1.40
Grasim Ind.....	2912.70	-24.70
HCL Tech.....	1461.80	-6.60
HDFC Bank.....	925.80	-21.90
HDFC Life.....	703.90	-7.10
Hindalco.....	907.45	-1.55
Hind Unilever.....	2319.00	-13.80
ICI Bank.....	1411.60	-3.00
IntGlobeAvi.....	4940.80	-11.60
Infosys.....	1365.60	-3.50
ITC.....	317.95	-4.20
Jio Financial Service.....	262.55	-1.40
JSW Steel.....	1248.20	-16.20
Kotak Bank.....	425.60	-4.95
Kwality Walls.....	29.42	-10.78
L&T.....	420.50	-27.60
M&M.....	3509.70	-23.70
Maruti Suzuki.....	1505.00	-186.00
Max Healthcare.....	1075.85	-22.25
NestleIndia.....	1289.80	-7.20
NTPC.....	369.10	-6.10
ONGC.....	271.55	-4.15
PowerGrid Corp.....	300.50	-13.30
Reliance Ind.....	1437.10	-17.50
SBI Life.....	2042.40	-8.20
State Bank.....	1208.10	-9.50
Shriram Finance.....	1085.40	-19.60
Sun Pharma.....	1700.50	-3.00
TataConsumerPro.....	1139.20	-7.00
Tata Steel.....	205.81	-2.63
TCS.....	2706.60	-14.40
Tech Mahindra.....	1512.70	-21.70
Titan.....	4181.10	-1.90
Tata Motors PV.....	377.25	-3.00
Trent Ltd.....	4229.50	-22.50
UltraTech Cement.....	12981.00	-18.00
Wipro.....	213.26	-0.83

Snapdeal fined ₹5 lakh

The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) has imposed a penalty of ₹5 lakh on Snapdeal for selling toys that do not comply with mandatory BIS certification.

‘India in demand by both developed countries and global south economies’

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
MUMBAI

India currently enjoys a place in the global economy where developed countries want to increasingly engage with it, while governments in smaller countries want India to anchor projects in their countries, Priyam Gandhi-Mody, the founder and chairperson of the Future Economic Cooperation Council (FECC) said.



Priyam Gandhi-Mody

The FECC is organising a three-day Global Economic Cooperation (GEC) summit in Mumbai on February 17-19, which will bring together delegations from both developed and developing countries.

The FECC is backed by the Ministry of External Affairs and the Govt. of Maharashtra. Ms. Gandhi-Mody said the ongoing global disruption is affecting every country, but simultaneously places India at an “interesting intersection”.

“On the one side, we have larger economies and blocs like the European Union, the U.S., Australia, and other countries in the developed world wanting to engage more with India,” she told *The Hindu*. “On the other side, the countries that are smaller, particularly in the global south, are looking at having India be the anchor of important projects in their countries, and do something jointly with India.”

(The reporter is at the GEC 2026 summit on the invitation of the FECC.)

Magnum Icecream to buy 26% in Kwality Walls

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The Netherlands-based Magnum Icecream Holdings is set to acquire 26% stake in Kwality Walls Ltd.

The total consideration of the acquisition is ₹1,303.03 crore, wherein Unilever Plc decided to sell a total of 61,08,93,729 equity shares, according to the public takeover notice.

High demand for domestic AI infrastructure: Neysa AI CEO

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

Sovereignty, latency and compliance are driving demand for domestic AI infrastructure among enterprise clients, said Neysa AI CEO Sharad Sanghi.

Mr. Sanghi spoke to *The Hindu* on the sidelines of the AI Impact Summit, hours after news broke that his firm had raised \$600 million from Blackstone, Inc., and was on the

road to borrow another \$600 million, for a war chest to procure GPUs to run AI on Indian servers.

Neysa’s fundraise is notable because the vast majority of AI “inferencing,” or responses to prompts, comes from datacentres abroad – a situation that causes little pain for retail users, but could be a source of discomfort for enterprises looking to incorporate sophisticated LLMs internally.

“Almost all the people who provide development platform want to set up increasing clusters in India,” Mr. Sanghi said.

“Now with the tax holiday [for datacentres processing data for foreign entities], they will use India as a hub not only for India but also for the region. That’s why we can be in dialogue with some of these large players and we are expecting to close some of the vendors.”

KERALA STATE ELECTRICITY BOARD LIMITED - EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
O/o The Chief Engineer, (REES & PED), Vidyuthi Bhavanam, Thiruvananthapuram.
Notice inviting Expression Of Interest (EOI) for ‘Proposals of Location’ towards Setting up EV Public Charging Stations (EV PCS) under the PM E-DRIVE Scheme in Kerala (Category-C) Open Invitation
EOI No. 02/CE/(REES)/25-26 dated 10.02.2026
Last Date & Time of submission of (EOI): 10.02.2026, 05 pm
Contact : EV Accelerator Cell, KSEBL 9th Floor, Vidyuthi Bhavanam, Pattom, Thiruvananthapuram - 695004.
Email/Phone pmedrive@ksebl.in / 0471 - 2514222
Visit www.etenders.kerala.gov.in and www.kseb.in Ref: PR/MC/1377/2026

RAJASTHAN RAJYA VIDYUT UTPADAN NIGAM LIMITED
CIN:- U40102RJ20005GCO16484 (A Govt. of Rajasthan Undertaking)
O/o CE (Civil), 7th floor, LIC Jeevan Deep Building, Lal Kothi, Jaipur
E-TENDER NOTICE: TNC-13 (RVU2526WSOB02305)
Online Tenders are invited for Strengthening and Special Repair of RCC Structure of Cooling Tower Unit#4 at STPS Plant, Suratgarh, Tender details are available on websites <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> (for e-tender), www.energy.rajjasthan.gov.in/rvuni and www.sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in.
Raj.Samwad/C25/19867 RVUN/PR-4348 Chief Engineer (Civil)

CSIR – INDIAN INSTITUTE OF CHEMICAL BIOLOGY
4, Raja SC Mullick Road, Jadavpur, Kolkata - 700032
SHORT TENDER NOTICE
1) Name of work: Annual Miscellaneous Electrical Maintenance work at CSIR-ICB Jadavpur and Salt Lake Campus Kolkata; 2) Estimated Cost ₹15 Lakh; 3) E-Tender No. 2026_CSIR_265951_1; 4) Publication date in C.P.P. portal – 17.02.2026; 5) For further details please visit <https://www.iicb.res.in/tenders>, and <https://etenders.gov.in/eprocure/app>.

Government of India
MINISTRY OF POWER
Vacancy for the Post of Chairman, Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB)
It is proposed to fill up the post of Chairman, Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB), a statutory organization under provision contained in Section 79(2) (a) of Punjab Reorganization Act, 1966.
The detailed Vacancy Circular may be seen at the website of Ministry of Power i.e. <https://powermin.gov.in/>.
Applications/nominations of suitable candidates having qualification and experience for appointment as Chairman, Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB) may be sent so as to reach the Ministry of Power latest by **11th March, 2026**, addressed to the Deputy Director (BBMB), Ministry of Power, Room No. 26, Shram Shakti Bhawan, Rafi Marg, New Delhi-110001. Applications/Nominations received after the last date will not be considered.
229-PR-BR-Board Sect-6 I FOR YOUR BETTER TOMORROW SAVE ENERGY TODAY

KERALA MARITIME BOARD
(A statutory Board of Govt. of Kerala)
HO TC XXII/1666 (4&5)
1st Floor, Mulamoottil Building, Pipinmoodu, Sasthamangalam, Pin: 695010.
EOI NOTICE
EOI for Development of 5 Acres of Port Land with Beachfront at Vizhinjam, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala
The Kerala Maritime Board (KMB) invites an Expression of Interest for the **Development of 5 Acres of Port Land with Beachfront at Vizhinjam, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala**
[EOI NO: HOKMB-TVM/180/2026-C1(Devp)] in Public Private Partnership (PPP) mode.
The detailed EOI document can be downloaded from the KMB Website (www.kmb.kerala.gov.in)
Proposals must be submitted on or before **30.03.2026, 03:00 PM**.
For further information contact us on **0471 - 2910040 / 9544410029** or email us to kmb.kerala@gmail.com
D3/159/2026/I&PRD

कोल इंडिया लिमिटेड
(एक महारल कंपनी)
“All the tenders issued by CIL and its Subsidiaries for procurement of Goods, Works and Services are available on website of Coal India Ltd www.coalindia.in / respective Subsidiary Company, CIL e-procurement portal <https://coalindiatictenders.nic.in> and Central Procurement Portal <https://eprocure.gov.in>. In addition, procurement is also done through GeM portal <https://gem.gov.in>.”

CENTRE FOR DEVELOPMENT OF IMAGING TECHNOLOGY (C-DIT)
Thiruvallam, Thiruvananthapuram - 27
Ph. 0471-2380910/912/895
TENDER NOTICE
C-DIT invites e tenders for “Providing i7 Laptops H Series (450 Nos) on daily rental basis for 30 days”
7786 Tender ID: 2026_CDIT_836678_1
Last Date: 25.02.2026, 3.00 PM
For details visit www.cditi.org
16.02.2026 Registrar, C-DIT

ANDHRA PRADESH POWER GENERATION CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Govt. of A.P Undertaking)
NOTIFICATION FOR APGENCO e-Procurement
NIT No. 610002213
APGENCO invites open tender for - PROCUREMENT OF APH BASKETS (HEATING ELEMENTS) FOR 27.5 VITM 1900 RAPH OF 210 MW Units of STAGE-I/Dr.MVR.RTPP through APGENCO e-procurement platform. Estimated Value of Contract: Rs.2,27,55,728/- Schedule available date & time: from 15:00Hrs onwards on 12.02.2026. Bid submission closing date & time: 04.03.2026 upto 13.00 Hrs, for further details visit: www.apgenco.gov.in or <https://etender.apgenco.gov.in/ri/portal/>). Phone: (0866) 2526808, 2526115, 2526139, DIPR 4835PP/CL, Dt: 16/02/2026

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER, RURAL WORKS CIRCLE : KEONJHAR
eMail: se_nerwkr@rediffmail.com
e Procurement Notice for Road Works under DMF
Bid Identification No. NCB-41/RWCCKJR/2025-26
No. 756 // Date : 12.02.2026 //
1. Name of the Work : Improvement of road from PWD road (Soso) to Adalapanka via Mouda Road from 0/000 Km. to 8/000 Km. in the District of Keonjhar for the year 2025-26.
3. Estimated Cost : Rs.718.92 Lakhs (Approximately)
4. Class of Contractor (Eligible) : 'A' & 'Special' Class of Contractor
5. Period of Completion : 12 (Twelve) Calendar Months
6. Other details:

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender On-line for bidding From To	Last Date & Time of Seeking Tender Clarification	Date & Time of Opening of Tender in OIO C.C.E., R.W.Circle, Keonjhar	Technical Bid	Financial Bid
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Keonjhar	NCB-41 / RWCKJR / 2025-26	DI.20.02.26 at 11:00 A.M. to DI.06.03.26 up to 5:00 P.M.	DI.05.03.26 up to 5:00 P.M.	DI.07.03.26 at 11:00 A.M.	Will be intimated later	

Further details can be seen from the website www.tendersorissa.gov.in
Sd/- Er.A.P.Kiro, Chief Construction Engineer, R.W.Circle, Keonjhar.
25001/174/2526 OIPR-25001/25177/1/25-26/0035

समुद्री उत्पाद निर्यात विकास प्राधिकरण
THE MARINE PRODUCTS EXPORT DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
(वाणिज्य एवं उद्योग मंत्रालय, भारत सरकार)
(Ministry of Commerce and Industry, Government of India)
एमपीईडीए हाउस, पनमिल्ली एवेन्यू / MPEDA House, Panampilly Avenue
कोच्चि/Kochi - 682036, केरल / Kerala.
(दूरभाष / Tel: 0484- 2311901) ईमेल/ Email : ho@mpeda.gov.in
वेबसाइट/ Website: www.mpeda.gov.in
कार्यकारी सहायक (अनुबंध आधार पर), टीपीओ, जापान
Executive Assistant (On Contract), TPO Japan
एमपीईडीए योग्य और इच्छुक उम्मीदवारों से एमपीईडीए व्यापार संवर्धन कार्यालय (टीपीओ) टोक्यो, जापान में कार्यकारी सहायक (अनुबंध आधार पर) के पद पर नियुक्ति के लिए अभियन्त्रित-रुचि (ईओआई) आमंत्रित करता है। ईओआई प्रस्तुत करने की अंतिम तिथि 04 मार्च 2026 है। विस्तृत जानकारी के लिए कृपया एमपीईडीए की वेबसाइट देखें। (अभिसूचना – अवसर – ओपनिंग लिस्ट)
MPEDA, invites Expression of Interest (EOI) from eligible and interested candidates for engagement as Executive Assistant (on contract) at the MPEDA Trade Promotion Office (TPO), Tokyo, Japan. Last date for submission of EOI is 04th March 2026. For detailed information, please visit MPEDA website (Notification – Opportunities – Opening List).
हस्ताक्षर/- Sd/-
उप निदेशक (कार्यक)
Deputy Director (Pers)

IN A LEAGUE OF HIS OWN

Masterful Rashid becomes the first to scale Mt. 700 in T20s



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Afghanistan skipper Rashid Khan became the first bowler to take 700 wickets in T20s. He reached the milestone during Afghanistan's T20 World Cup match against the UAE in New Delhi, where he dismissed Muhammad Arfan in his final over. Rashid averages 18.51 after 518 games, with a strike rate of 16.8 and an economy of 6.59.

BOUNCING BACK

Afghanistan's performance under pressure pleases coach Trott



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

(The) UAE played really well, and we were under pressure, but that's the pleasing thing for me as a coach. At the end of the day, when you come out on the right side of pressure situations, like we were, having the history of the last game (against South Africa), I've certainly seen a shift — Afghanistan head coach Jonathan Trott.

OUCH!

Spectator hit by a Jacks missile in the England-Italy WC game



K.R. DEEPAK

England all-rounder Will Jacks went on a boundary-hitting spree in the T20 World Cup match against Italy in Kolkata on Monday, with one of his four sixes injuring a spectator in the Eden Gardens stands. The woman had to be rushed for medical attention after being hit by the ball on the face.

FICKLE GAME

We haven't played our best cricket, but we've got through: Brook



K.R. DEEPAK

We haven't played our best cricket, but at the end of the day, we've got through and we're heading to the next round. So, we can be happy about that. We haven't managed to string together the scores that we'd like to do as a batting unit, but that's part of T20 cricket. It's a fickle game — England captain Harry Brook.

Omarzai sizzles, keeps Afghanistan in the hunt

T20 WORLD CUP

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

An upside of the short turnaround between group-stage matches in the T20 World Cup is that the players don't have to brood over disappointments for long. Azmatullah Omarzai will concur after his match-winning display against the UAE at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Monday.

Five days after Omarzai bowled a costly Super Over against South Africa in Ahmedabad, the 25-year-old found joy with bat and ball. The Afghanistan all-rounder claimed four for 15 to restrict the UAE to 160 for nine, and smashed an unbeaten 40 off 21 balls to help his side hunt down the target in 19.2 overs.

Afghanistan's first win of this edition gives it hope of sneaking into the Super Eight stage.

Having elected to bowl, Afghanistan snared two wickets early, reducing the Middle-East outfit to 13 for two. Omarzai made the opening breakthrough of Aryansh Sharma.

Alishan Sharafu and Sohaib Khan counter-attacked with an 84-run alliance for the third wicket.

Once Sharafu holed out at long-off off Mujeeb Ur Rahman in the 12th over, though, the Afghan attack tightened the noose. The UAE managed just 63 runs off the last 52 deliveries.

The run chase was laced with twists and turns. After Rahmanullah Gurbaz and Gulbadin Naib departed in-



Omarzai. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

side the PowerPlay, Ibrahim Zadran steadied the ship with a half-century. But with 64 needed off seven overs, Zadran pulled Muhammad Arfan to deep midwicket.

Darwish Rasooli and Omarzai forged a 43-run stand for the fifth wicket, and the latter hit Muhammad Jawadullah for a six and four in the penultimate over. When Omarzai hit the winning runs in the final over, Afghanistan heaved a sigh of relief.

The scores: UAE 160/9 in 20 overs (Sharafu 40, Sohaib 68, Omarzai 4/15, Mujeeb 2/31) lost to Afghanistan 162/5 in 19.2 overs (Ibrahim Zadran 53, Rasooli 33, Omarzai 40 n.o., Siddique 2/23, Arfan 2/30); **Toss:** Afghanistan; **PoM:** Omarzai.

Ton-up Nissanka leaves Australia on the brink

The opener's scintillating knock takes Lanka into Super Eight with ease; Kusal Mendis hits a fifty; Hemantha's three-for proves vital in bowling out the 2021 champion for 181 after its dream start

Anish Pathivil
PALLEKELE

It is not often you see an Australian team walk around the field with drooping shoulders. The reaction was logical in view of what transpired at the Pallekele International Cricket Stadium here on Monday. Egged on by the vociferous home support, Sri Lanka trumped the Aussies by eight wickets to push them to the brink of elimination from the ICC T20 World Cup.

Pathum Nissanka (100 n.o., 52b, 10x4, 5x6) and Kusal Mendis (51, 38b, 6x4, 1x6) chose precision over power to put up a 97-run second-wicket stand, which helped the home side chase down the 182-run target with two overs to spare.

Supporting role

Pavan Rathnayake ensured Kusal's wicket didn't trigger a collapse mirroring the first innings, playing the perfect foil to Nissanka's batting masterclass at the other end against a crestfallen bowling attack. Within the blink of an eye, the opener raced to his second T20I hundred to guide his side through to the Super Eight stage.

Earlier, Steve Smith's addition to the squad as Josh Hazlewood's replacement prompted suggestions that Mitchell Marsh was not



Masterclass: Nissanka brought up his second T20I hundred off just 52 balls. AP

ready to take the field.

But it was the captain (54, 27b, 8x4, 2x6) who strode out alongside Travis Head (56, 29b, 7x4, 3x6) to give the team a blistering start it was longing for in this tournament.

The Australian openers punished the opponent's inability to stick to a nagging line, racing to a 104-run partnership within

nine overs. The tables turned once both fell to Dushan Hemantha (three for 37) after their rapid half-centuries.

The rest of the batting order, barring a brief partnership between Josh Inglis and Glenn Maxwell, looked to inflate the scoring rate without accounting for the turn on offer for the tweekers, resulting in a

flurry of wickets. With just 71 runs to show in its final 10 overs, it was clear where Australia lost the plot.

The scores:

Australia 181 in 20 overs (Mitchell Marsh 54, Travis Head 56, Dushmantha Chameera 2/36, Dushan Hemantha 3/37) lost to Sri Lanka 184/2 in 18 overs (Pathum Nissanka 100 n.o., Kusal Mendis 51, Marcus Stoinis 2/46). **Toss:** Lanka; **PoM:** Nissanka.

Jacks on fire as England edges Italy, reaches Super Eight

Agence France-Presse
KOLKATA

England survived a scare to qualify for the Super Eight at the T20 World Cup on Monday as Italy's spirited chase of 203 fell agonisingly short in a pulsating match in Kolkata.

Will Jacks scored the fastest fifty for England in T20 World Cup history as it made 202 for seven and eventually won by 24 runs.

Italy was on track to pull off a sensational upset when Grant Stewart and Jaspreet Singh blasted 21 off Adil Rashid's final over, the 17th of the chase, including three sixes.

That left 30 needed off 12 balls, but it proved too much and Italy was all out off the last ball of the match for 178.

Earlier, most of England's batsmen got good starts after Harry Brook chose to bat.

But only Jacks capitalised as Italy kept chipping away with regular wickets. He reached his fifty off 21 balls to beat Eoin Morgan's



Dazzling display: Jacks scored the fastest fifty for England in T20 World Cup history. K.R. DEEPAK

25-ball effort against the West Indies in Kandy in 2012. Jacks took the game by the scruff of the neck after England stuttered to 105 for five in the 13th over.

He put on 54 off 25 balls with Sam Curran (25) for the sixth wicket and 35 off 16 balls with Jamie Overton (15) for the seventh.

Jacks remained unbeaten on 53 off 22 balls.

The scores: England 202/7 in 20 overs (Tom Banton 30, Will Jacks 53 n.o., Grant Stewart 2/51, Crishan Kalugamage 2/41) bt Italy 178 in 20 overs (Justin Mosca 43, Ben Manenti 60, Grant Stewart 45, Jofra Archer 2/35, Jamie Overton 3/18, Sam Curran 3/22). **Toss:** England; **PoM:** Jacks.

Associate nations need to get better in game awareness



Sunil Gavaskar

The ICC T20 World Cup is the best chance for the emerging teams to show how much progress they have made in the two years since the previous edition. Unlike the ODI World Cup, which occurs every four years, the T20 World Cup is a biennial affair and is one tournament where the Associate nations have a good chance of surprising the full member teams.

It hasn't quite happened in this edition. Yes, Zimbabwe beat Australia, but they are not only a full member team and have also done it in the past in the ODI World Cup. Nepal had a very good chance to beat England, but came up against Sam Curran. The experienced all-rounder ensured England got through by the skin of their teeth by bowling an over



full of superb yorkers.

The USA and the UAE have shown that they are the pick of the emerging countries and both these teams have benefitted immensely from their players featuring in their domestic T20 leagues, the MLC and the IL T20, where some of the best-known overseas stars also take part.

The one area where emerging teams need to get better is the catching, especially at game-changing moments. It's here that they let themselves down and leave the door open to a more experienced team to get away. If this is a technical aspect which can be improved by more and more practice, the other shortcoming is more of a

temperament issue. The temptation to go for the glory shot often results in dismissals when smart batting would take them to a win. Today's bats and shorter boundaries do make batters believe they can hit the maximums, but for lower-order players to attempt the six rather than give strike to the more accomplished and well-settled batter at the other end, has often allowed the fielding side to sneak through from a losing position.

That said, the emerging teams have been a breath of fresh air and their enthusiasm and liveliness have added to the fun and excitement.

(Professional Management Group)

Points table						
GROUP A						
	M	W	L	PTS	NRR	
India (Q)	3	3	0	6	3.050	
USA	4	2	2	4	0.788	
Pakistan	3	2	1	4	-0.403	
Netherlands	3	1	2	2	-1.352	
Namibia	3	0	3	0	-2.443	
GROUP B						
	M	W	L	PTS	NRR	
Sri Lanka (Q)	3	3	0	6	2.462	
Zimbabwe	2	2	0	4	1.984	
Australia	3	1	2	2	0.414	
Ireland	3	1	2	2	0.150	
Oman	3	0	3	0	-4.546	
GROUP C						
	M	W	L	PTS	NRR	
West Indies (Q)	3	3	0	6	1.820	
England (Q)	4	3	1	6	0.201	
Scotland	3	1	2	2	0.359	
Italy	3	1	2	2	-0.588	
Nepal	3	0	3	0	-1.942	
GROUP D						
	M	W	L	PTS	NRR	
South Africa (Q)	3	3	0	6	1.477	
New Zealand	3	2	1	4	0.701	
Afghanistan	3	1	2	2	-0.215	
UAE	3	1	2	2	-0.797	
Canada	2	0	2	0	-1.526	

Q: QUALIFIED

M CH-CHE

Ireland match becomes the most important one, reckons Raza

Nepal vs. Scotland: meaningless on paper, meaningful in message

Morikawa triumphs

Padikkal and Smaran pile on the agony for Uttarakhand

Dogra and Samad's knocks revive Jammu & Kashmir against Bengal

The game makes you a strong human, says milestone-man Dogra

Sport



Mission accomplished: Movva has realised his dream of playing at the highest level. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

Movva wants to keep his love for the game and coding going

The wicketkeeper-batter, who played in Davanagere and Bengaluru, revived his passion for the game after moving to Canada in 2016

CRICKET

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

Life is about balancing passion and profession for Canada's wicketkeeper-batter Shreyas Movva.

The 32-year-old, born in Davanagere in Karnataka, moved to Montreal in 2016 for higher studies in software engineering. There, he played cricket and broke into the National team, becoming the first from the Quebec region to do so.

He is enjoying the opportunity to play in the

T20 showpiece and is keen to continue his job as a software professional even while pursuing the willow game. "I would love to do the software job after the World Cup and also cricket, as it is my passion," said Movva on the eve of the Group D game against New Zealand here.

Having played all his cricket in Davanagere and Bengaluru, he took a break once his engineering was done and gave himself a chance to play for the Karnataka State team.

"After my engineering course, I took a one-year break to give myself one more chance to play for the State and took part in

the zonals and probables matches," said Movva.

Not being able to further his cricket ambitions in Karnataka, Movva turned his attention back to academics and headed to Montreal to study at Concordia University.

"It was my mom's dream. She has a triple degree to her name. She motivated me and used to tell me where there is a will, there is a way. I was not good at studies. I just wanted to do it for her," he said about the decision to focus on academics and shift base to Canada.

Yet, he is keen to continue his love affair with cricket.

Real gets Mbappe boost for Benfica showdown

Associated Press
MADRID

With Kylian Mbappé back in the squad, Real Madrid returns to Portugal looking for some payback against José Mourinho's Benfica in the Champions League.

Three weeks after Mourinho's team stunned his former club in a 4-2 win that allowed Benfica to qualify and kept the Spanish giant from automatically reaching the round of 16, the two teams will meet again in the first round of the knockout stage.

"I hope history does not repeat itself," Madrid coach Álvaro Arbeloa said. "We are prepared for the difficulty of the match, the opponent, the atmosphere and what awaits us on Tuesday.

Mbappé, who already has 38 goals for Madrid this season, will be available again after he missed the Spanish league match against Real Sociedad at the weekend because of discomfort on his knee.

Champions League schedule Galatasaray vs. Juventus (11:15 p.m. on Tuesday) PSG vs. AS Monaco Benfica vs. Real Madrid, Borussia Dortmund vs. Atalanta (1:30 a.m. on Wednesday)

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: ICC T20 World Cup, Group D, New Zealand vs Canada, MAC Stadium, 11 a.m.

AROUND THE CITY

Sachin, Boopathi bowl TN to a thumping win

Left-arm spinner Sachin Rathi and off-spinner M. Boopathi Vaishna Kumar helped Tamil Nadu bowl out Madhya Pradesh for 280 and register an innings and 108-victory on day four of the seventh-round Elite-C Col. C.K. Nayudu Trophy match in Indore on Monday. TN entered the quarterfinals.

The scores (seventh round): Elite-C (day four): Madhya Pradesh 186 & 280 in 84.2 overs (Chanchal Rathore 57, Avnesh Chawla 52, Ishan Chaudhary 48 n.o., Sachin Rathi 3/76, M. Boopathi Vaishna Kumar 3/24) lost to Tamil Nadu 574.

Andhra beats TN

K. Anjali Saravani (55 and three for 26) set up Andhra's 99-run win over Tamil Nadu in the fifth-round Elite-D BCCI Senior Women One Day Trophy match in Guwahati.

The scores: Elite-D: Andhra 227 in 50 overs (Henrietta Pereira 46, K. Anjali Saravani 55, N. Sarathi Priya 4/51, M.S. Aishwarya 3/32) bt Tamil Nadu 128 in 42.1 overs (K. Anjali Sarvani 3/26).

Kothandaraman scalps five in Pegasus' big win

Medium-pacer M. Kothandaraman's five for 14 helped Pegasus SC beat Chennai Corporation OA by 217 runs in a Zone-A match of the TNCA sixth division league.

The scores: III-B: IOB SC 92 in 27.4 overs (V. Krishnan 3/13, S. Arunachalam 4/8 incl. hat-trick) lost to Triplicane SC 96/2 in 20.4 overs (S. Mohamed Ibrahim 35 n.o., S. Sachin 34 n.o.).

Fox Trotters 126/9 in 50 overs (N.S.



Star performers: Top: Arunachalam (Triplicane SC, 4/8 incl. hat-trick); Vinobhaji (Anna varsity, 3/18 incl. hat-trick); Kothandaraman (Pegasus, 5/14); Vijayaragavan (Chennai P&T, 109 n.o.); Madan (Anna varsity, 105 n.o.); Emasagar (MFL, 5/30); Bottom: Manipal (IAF Tbm, 136 n.o.); Aadhi (Sridhar, 5/47); Prababhar (TSR, 5/51); Rokins (AGORC, 135); Mukeshwaran (Tiger, 104); Avaikkarasan (TSR, 101 n.o.).

Seshamani 33 n.o., B. Akashkumar 36, B. Rocky 4/26, R. Adithya 3/14) lost to Aruna 129/3 in 24.3 overs (Sanjay Venkateshwar 55 n.o., R. Krishnamoorthy 30).

Garnet 246/8 in 50 overs (R. Rajan 81, S. Suresh Kumar 40, U. Sasidev 45, R. Mithun 42) bt Singam Puli 141 in 37.4 overs (S. Vijay 76, S. Boopalan 3/29, R. Divakar 3/25). Sir M.C.T.M Old Boys SA 214 in 48.2 overs (E. Tamizh Dhileepan 30, B. Praanesh 71, M. Sreeman 34, B. Arvind 4/42) lost to Prem 216/2 in 46.5 overs (G. Surender 75 n.o., S. Ram Narayan 83 n.o.).

The scores: Elite-D: Andhra 227 in 50 overs (Henrietta Pereira 46, K. Anjali Sarvani 55, N. Sarathi Priya 4/51, M.S. Aishwarya 3/32) bt Tamil Nadu 128 in 42.1 overs (K. Anjali Sarvani 3/26).

Tamizhhasan 3/43, Sidarth Ravi 3/40); Madras Aryan Club 268/7 in 50 overs (Karthik Shankar 48, P.S. Raghu 59, K. Barath Kumar 69) tied with AG's Office RC 268 in 49.5 overs (P. Francis Rokins 135, M. Prabhu 3/33); AG's Office won the Super Over.

IV-B: Tiger 295 in 50 overs (A.R. Siva Murugan 40, T.T. Kishore 38, Sree Mukeshwaran 104, R. Vivek 64, P. Vijaya Prabaha 5/51) lost to TSR MSC 296/4 in 48 overs (H. Harish Akshay 31, D. Govindaraj 53, M. Santhosh Gopi 30, S. Avaikkarasan 101 n.o., Kevin Noel

Isaac 48 n.o.).

V-B: Madras University Union 219/9 in 50 overs (M. Deni Kishore 52, A. Gokulraaj 30, K. Devendra Jajria 3/28) lost to IAF (Tbm) 221/9 in 49.2 overs (Manipal Singh 136 n.o., Richhpal 30 n.o., M. Karthikeyan 5/61).

V-D: Grove 138 in 35.5 overs (Barath 87, S. Rohit 4/30, R. Rohit Ram 3/29) lost to Kovai Knights 139/5 in 31.2 overs (R. Venkatesh 37 n.o.); Chennai P&T Audit 255/5 in 50 overs (S. Yuvaneshwaran 75, B. Vijayaragavan 109 n.o.) lost to Companions 256/4 in 34 overs (Mohammed Aaryan Sajid 35, M. Arun 65, K. Mathan 72, S. Varun 58 n.o.).

Sridhar 203 in 45.5 overs (V. Ram Vishal 57, K. Tarun Avinash 31, M.A. Stephen Raj 3/48) bt Youngsters 163 in 41.5 overs (B. Karthik 31, P. Poovarasani 53, V. Karuppusamy 30 n.o., R. Aadhi Kesavan 5/47).

Shivaji 198/9 in 50 overs (S. Judian Benhur 50, S.M. Dharanivasan 34, S. Nagul Prathish 3/34, K. Ajith Kumar 3/62) bt Free Lancers 147 in 43.3 overs (S. Mahesh 43, G. Thirumoorathi 36, H. Balaji 4/56, E. Sudarsun 3/16).

VI-A: Pegasus SC 241/7 in 30 overs (R. Sowndararajan 56, K. Badri Sayee 45, T. Velmurugan 63 n.o., D.K. Vigneshwar 31) bt Chennai Corporation OA 24 in 12.5 overs (N. Kothandaraman 5/14, T. Velmurugan 3/8). Jai Hind 163 in 29.1 overs (Ajay

Dueman 40, P. Ajay 34, Srivats Ganapathiraman 3/35, G. Shravan 3/38) bt Eccentrics 143 in 27.1 overs (G. Shravan 34, Anirudh 4/41, A. Syed Akif Perran 3/23, A. Karthik 3/30).

VI-B: Kohinoor XI 130 in 29 overs (T.A. Prasanna Kumar 30, T. Muthuazhagan 55, D. Vinobhaji 3/18 incl. hat-trick, P. Karthik Sharan 3/37) lost to Anna University SB 136/3 in 20.4 overs (G. Madan Kumar 105 n.o.).

TFUCC 129/9 in 30 overs (P. Prasanth 54, K. Jagadeesh 3/22, K. Sukumar 3/44) lost to Minerva 133/7 in 29.1 overs (R. Chinnarasu 30, K. Rajesh Kumar 54, Naveen 3/26); MFL RC 155/8 in 30 overs (R. Prajanth 47, Srinivasan 63 n.o., U. Gunaseelan 4/23, D. Krishna Kumar 3/27) bt Ashok Leyland AA 150/8 in 30 overs (U. Gunaseelan 36, K. Emasagar 5/30).

Children's chess

SJ Chess Academy will conduct the Rotary Club of Chennai Carnatic first Checkmate TN-level children's tournament (u-8, 10, 12, 16 boys and girls) on Feb. 22 at Sree Balaji Dental College and Hospital, Pallikaranai. Call R. Muthukumar at 9500912898 or H. Santhanam at 9840583157.

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Chief Engineer / PP&R Organization, Shed No. D-3, Shakti Vihar, PSPCL, Patiala invites E-tender under three-part bid system for banking of power from interstate utilities / traders, Traders having valid Inter State Trading Licence issued by CERC for interstate trading of energy, State Electricity Boards, State Electricity Utilities, States from 1st March 2026 to 10th October 2026. For detailed NIT & tender specifications please refer to <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> from 12.02.2026 onwards.
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1. Name of the Work : Construction of Block level Stadium (with Indoor Hall) in Bonal Block under Sundargarh District
2. Value of the Work : Rs.1293.51 lakhs
3. Period of completion : 9 (Nine) Calendar Months
4. Availability of tender online for Bidding :
i. Start Date : 18:00 Hours of Dt.18.02.2026
ii. End Date : 17:00 Hours of dt.06.03.2026
iii. Opening date : 11:30 Hours of dt.07.03.2026
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1. Name of the Work : Construction of Block level Stadium, Sahrapada under Keonjhar District with O&M for 05 years
2. Value of the Work (Approx. Excluding O&M) : Rs.12.42 Crore.
3. Period of completion : 09 (Nine) Calendar Months
4. Availability of tender online for Bidding :
i. Start Date : 18:00 Hours of Dt. 19.02.2026
ii. End Date : 15:00 Hours of dt.09.03.2026
iii. Opening date : 16:00 Hours of dt.09.03.2026
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ANNUAL DAY CELEBRATED



GT Aloha Vidhya Mandir School celebrated their 16th Annual Day, 'Reflexionz 2K25', on the theme "Pathram, Pushpam, Pazham". The programme began with the traditional lighting of the lamp and an invocation dance. Principal Dr. J. Sundar presented the Annual Report. Correspondent Mr. Bharat Kanti Doshi honoured Chief Guest Mr. Bajju Gopalan, Managing Director of Sree Gokulam Group of Companies, who presented awards and scholarships. The school magazine Impressions

2K25 was unveiled. Students from Kindergarten to Class XII showcased vibrant cultural performances aligned with the theme.

MARTYRS' DAY OBSERVED

B.V. Bhavan's Rajaji Vidyashram students, along with Music Teachers, performed patriotic songs at the Martyrs' Day event at Gandhi Mandapam. They also participated in the 'Vande Mataram' 150th celebration exhibition at Raj Bhavan, gaining meaningful and enriching experiences at both venues.



ANNUAL DAY CELEBRATED



RMK Patashaala celebrated their Annual Day with cultural splendour. Chief Guest Thiru. G. Suguna Singh, IPS, accompanied by Mrs. Dhanalakshmi Suguna Singh, graced the occasion, which was presided over by Vidhya Ratna Shri R. S. Munirathnam, Founder Chairman. Management dignitaries and advisors attended under the guidance of Principal Smt. Chandrika Prasad. Students presented vibrant performances, including Jungle Trek, Colours and Ramayanam – Mega Depiction. Board toppers and teachers with centum results were honoured. Rig House received the Overall Championship Rolling Trophy.

For Subscription related queries, please contact Subramaniam P: Handphone:+91 98408 98088 | Email: subramaniam.p@thehindu.co.in

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1. Name of the Work : Construction of Block level Stadium (with Indoor Hall) in Tangarpalli Block under Sundargarh District.
2. Value of the Work : Rs.1365.36 lakhs
3. Period of completion : 9 (Nine) Calendar Months
4. Availability of tender online for Bidding :
i. Start Date : 18:00 Hours of Dt.18.02.2026
ii. End Date : 17:00 Hours of dt.05.03.2026
iii. Opening date : 11:30 Hours of dt.06.03.2026
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Growth in Tamil Nadu is not measured only by numbers, but by improved lives. Investments in education, health, infrastructure, and employment continue to transform progress into everyday opportunity.

In Tamil Nadu's march to prosperity, we shall leave no one behind!



R. Kaushik
COLOMBO

In what now seems like the distant past, cricket matches between India and Pakistan were gripping affairs, steeped in tension and nerves, and extraordinary quality. There was an array of glittering superstars in both camps; India had the batting, Pakistan a seemingly endless supply of high-class fast bowlers who, to misquote Geoffrey Boycott, could obtain swing with even an orange.

Contests between these two proud nations were exactly that - contests that were no holds barred. Contrary to this age where players don't even look in each other's direction, let alone shake hands and exchange pleasantries, Indian and Pakistani stars struck up long-lasting friendships that have stood the test of time. Nothing illustrates the bond formed in those days better than the Shaz and Waz camaraderie - Ravi Shastri and Wasim Akram continue to be great friends whose relationship isn't based on nationality. But we digress. Or do we?

Even in this competitive era where professionalism has been lent new meaning, it is not as if friendships and relationships don't exist between players from different countries. Virat Kohli shares an excellent rapport with his brother from another mother, A.B. de Villiers, and with Faf du Plessis, under whom he played for Royal Challengers Bengaluru after giving up the captaincy. But when it comes to India and Pakistan, whatever happens on the field is alone what happens. There is nothing that happens off it, and even on the field, apart from the tussle between bat and ball, nothing is being allowed to happen anymore.

Even a year back, it wasn't so. While the countries were at loggerheads politically, nothing stopped the players from extending a hand of friendship. Everything changed after the April 22 Pahalgam attack in which 26 innocent civilian tourists lost their lives after a dastardly, cowardly terror attack. In the first senior men's cricketing outing between the nations in Dubai in September, Suryakumar Yadav studiously refrained from shaking hands with Salman Agha at the T20 Asia Cup, unquestionably following instructions from his bosses, who themselves might have been following instructions from theirs.

That set off a crazy sequence of events that has done no one any credit. Sport isn't just about turning up on the field of play, getting the job done - one way or the other - and going their separate ways. It is intended to foster bonds and forge goodwill but clearly, neither of that is on India's agenda, at the very least.

The brouhaha that accompanied the no-handshake policy in Dubai was conspicuously absent in Colombo on Sunday when the teams locked horns in a Group A league fixture of the T20 World Cup. Suryakumar had been pointedly asked at the pre-match presser if he would offer a handshake, to which he replied nonchalantly and without the seriousness the question demanded: "Wait for 24 hours and you will find out." A few hours previously, Agha was asked what his reaction would be if a handshake was forthcoming from his Indian counterpart. He was equally coy while saying, "You will know tomorrow."

In the end, we never could discover what Pakistan's stance would have been, because Suryakumar's hand remained steadfastly by his side. Match referee Richie Richardson, the former West Indian captain, had, one presumes, made everything clear so that there were no misgivings and there was no scope for miscommunication. Suryakumar flipped the coin, Agha called, called right, spoke first to Pommie Mbangwa, then whirled away towards his dugout as Suryakumar walked up to explain his team's strategy and the personnel changes India had rung in. The entire episode barely registered a 1 on the Richter Scale, perhaps so insensitive have we become to something that goes against the very ethos of sport.

Glorious past

It isn't this alone that has changed when it comes to India, Pakistan and cricket. As briefly alluded to at the top of this piece, this is no longer a battle of equals. The days when Sachin Tendulkar went toe to toe with Akram and Waqar Younis, or Mohammad Azharuddin and Sourav Ganguly were tested by Saqlain Mushtaq, are in the past. Irfan Pathan's screaming inswing that netted him a first-over hat-trick in the Karachi Test of 2006 or Anil Kumble's craft and guile that made him just the second man (at that time) in history to take all 10 Test wickets in an innings in Delhi in 1999, are well and truly behind us.

Occasionally, Pakistan will roll the clock back and trouble, even overcome, India - like in the T20 World Cup league clash in Dubai in 2021 or in an Asia Cup Super Four tie at the same venue a year later. But for the most part, it's been India and India alone for the last decade and more. In ODI World Cups, India hold a perfect 8-0 record while in its T20 counterpart, they enjoy an overwhelming 8-1 record. Sunday night's 61-run drubbing, eked out in the shadow of the boycott that wasn't, was the perfect illustration of why India enjoy a combined



India vs. Pakistan — a rivalry only in reams of newsprint

Matches between the sides were gripping affairs but that seems to be a thing of the past; the former holds a perfect 8-0 record in ODI World Cups and an 8-1 advantage in the T20 showpiece; Sunday's contest in Colombo showed the increasing gulf in terms of quality



A study in contrast: While the Indians have mastered the art of keeping emotions aside when facing their biggest rivals, the Pakistanis have often crumbled under the weight of pressure and expectations. GETTY IMAGES

16-1 advantage over their neighbours in all World Cups. The better team doesn't always carry the night, especially in 20-over cricket; it's the team that plays better in those three and a half hours that comes out triumphant. India didn't just play the better cricket, they were clearly the better team who have perfected the art of setting emotion aside even though they aren't churlish enough to hide behind 'This is just another match' platitudes and cliches.

On match eve, Suryakumar conceded that there would be pressure, more than normal, because that was the nature of India-Pakistan battles. It's a view his deputy Axar Patel echoed after the commanding victory had been sealed and delivered, with a cute bow tie on top. As much as the players might try to insulate themselves from 'outside noise', there is always a message here, a word there, an entreaty from somewhere else, to 'beat them.' How can one not be influenced by such factors? The trick is not to fight it but ride with it, and that's something Indian teams have managed successfully over the years. To try to keep harping that this is just another game, which it clearly isn't, will be nothing if not counterproductive.

But as they say in cricket, you play the ball and not the bowler, and therefore you play the opponent, not the banner under which the opponent has turned out. Through successive generations of performers, India have found the perfect way to embrace the pressure without allowing themselves to be overwhelmed by it, which might be a simplistic way of explaining their unmatched superiority but which also is most certainly a major contributing factor.

Fearless mindset

In Colombo, India were turbo-charged by the electric, effervescent, diminutive Ishan Kishan, who reiterated that wonderful things come in small packages.

The days when Tendulkar went toe to toe with Akram and Waqar, or Azharuddin and Ganguly were tested by Saqlain symbolised the competitive nature of the duels

To imbibe the daredevilry he showcased on a stage such as the World Cup and an occasion that involved their fiercest rivals as their opponents called for a special mindset, a mindset bereft of self-doubt and the fear of failure.

Often, the fear of failure is more debilitating than failure itself; inorganic conservatism comes with a massive no-no attached to it because that's how the natural order of things are. Kishan didn't try to play differently just because he was up against Pakistan and could/would be pilloried if he was dismissed attempting an outrageous stroke. True, he had the full backing of the leadership group to stick to what comes naturally and best to him. But even so, to be able to go out and bat the way he did on a surface that tested the mettle of everyone who came out to bat was great credit to the 27-year-old's thinking process and the extraordinarily positive headspace he has cultivated.

Kishan wasn't risk-averse so much as calculating in the kind of risks he took. He played the percentages wonderfully well, and because his off-side game has improved by leaps and bounds, he can no longer be tied down by packing one side of the wicket and staying away from his areas of strength. He was both the trend-setter and the enforcer, the brutal ball-basher whose 77 off 40 on a pitch where everyone else struggled was more than worth its weight in pure gold.

Perhaps because they believed the floaty lies around them or perhaps because they themselves were convinced

so, Pakistan banked on spin to do the job for them. Spin did, and it didn't, if you know what we mean; between them, Mohammad Nawaz, Saim Ayub and Usman Tariq, hyped up by the Indian media more than anyone else, finished with four for 77 from 12 overs, just reward for sticking to their disciplines and allowing the pitch to do the rest. Leggies Abrar Ahmed and Shadab Khan bowled poorly and were mercilessly punished, taken for 55 in four wicketless overs. Shaheen Afridi, a *bete noire* until three years ago for his ability to swing the ball back into the right-handers at great pace from a left-arm over angle, was reduced to two token but massively expensive overs that leaked 31.

By contrast, India's less talked-up spinners - lest we should forget, Varun Chakaravarthy is the No. 1 T20I bowler in the world - joined hands for a combined six for 80 from 13 overs while their fast bowlers, the peerless Jasprit Bumrah and Pakistani nemesis Hardik Pandya, boasted four for 33 from five overs. Pakistan used only two overs of pace, one at either end of their bowling innings; India's quicks bowled the first four overs of the Pakistani chase. By the end of the second over, a target of 176 appeared Everest-ian, the top three gone with just 13 on the board. India reiterated that there is no substitute for quality; it wasn't so much about pace alone or spin alone but about using a blend of the two judiciously, trusting quality and immense skill-sets and refusing to be drawn into cute theories and a heightened estimation of one's craft and strengths.

For all the hype in the lead-up to a match that nearly didn't happen until it finally did, this contest was singularly disappointing, flat and one-sided. How long do we continue to whip up this rivalry when clearly, it is a rivalry only in reams of newsprint, in the digital space or on airwaves but no longer on the field of play?

THE GIST

Occasionally, Pakistan will roll the clock back and trouble, even overcome, India - like in the T20 World Cup league clash in Dubai in 2021 or in an Asia Cup Super Four tie at the same venue a year later. But for the most part, it's been India and India alone for the last decade and more

Through successive generations of performers, India have found the perfect way to embrace the pressure without allowing themselves to be overwhelmed by it

The trick is not to fight the external factors but ride with them... that's something the Indian teams have managed successfully over the years

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of private hospitals' licence cancelled in U.P.

178 Uttar Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak said that the licences of 178 private hospitals in the State were cancelled, of which the licences of 59 hospitals were revived after a hearing. Mr. Pathak said, "Around 500 complaints were received..." PTI

The amount paid to farmers affected by rains in Gujarat

9,610 in ₹ crore. Gujarat governor Acharya Devvrat said the State government has disbursed ₹9,610 crore as part of a special agricultural relief package to more than 33 lakh farmers affected by unseasonal rains last year. PTI

Quantity of sugar India has exported till February 2025-26

2.01 In lakh tonnes. India has exported 2,01,547 tonnes of sugar through February in the current 2025-26 marketing year, with the UAE being the top destination. Sugar exports remain under government control through quotas distributed proportionally among mills. PTI

Number of tourist arrivals recorded in Kerala in 2025

2.58 In crore. Kerala tourism Minister P. A. Mohammed Riyas said that 2025 witnessed the highest number of tourist arrivals in Kerala's history. Compared to 2024, an additional 28,95,002 tourists visited Kerala in 2025. Domestic tourist arrivals increased by 12.64%. PTI

Indian fishermen apprehended by the Sri Lanka Navy

25 The Sri Lanka Navy apprehended 25 Indian fishermen for allegedly poaching in the island nation's territorial waters. The fishermen were apprehended and seized in Sri Lankan waters off Kankesanthurai, Jaffna, the Navy said. PTI

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A separate classification for denotified tribes

Why were Denotified, Nomadic, and Semi-Nomadic Tribes classified as 'criminal' groups in the colonial era? What did the Idate Commission recommend? What was the problem with the SEED scheme rolled out by the Social Justice Ministry? Why do community leaders demand a separate classification for DNTs?

EXPLAINER

Abhinay Lakshman

The story so far:

In January 30, the Union government assured community leaders from Denotified, Nomadic, and Semi-Nomadic Tribes (DNTs) that the Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India had agreed to enumerate these communities in the upcoming second phase of the Census due in 2027. However, with no clarity on how this enumeration will be conducted, leaders of these communities are organising to push for their demand for a "separate column" for DNTs in the Census form. This demand has found support from academics and scholars, who have noted that the demand for a Census count of DNTs has been reiterated time and again by successive Commissions that have been set up to examine their condition in society.

Who are the DNTs?

The communities referred to as denotified, nomadic, and semi-nomadic tribes were, at one point, classified as "criminal" by colonial administrators, who had concluded that there were certain communities "addicted" to committing crimes. This was codified in the Criminal Tribes Act (CTA), first introduced in 1871, the same year that synchronous Censuses began in India.

The CTA, 1871, was introduced for the "registration, surveillance and control of certain criminal tribes and eunuchs", describing "criminal tribes" as a "tribe, gang, or class of persons" that are "addicted" to committing non-bailable offences. While introducing the legislation, then Member of Law and Order, T.V. Stephens had said that, "the special feature of India is the caste system... Keeping this in mind, the meaning of professional criminal is clear. It means a tribe whose ancestors were criminals from times immemorial, who are themselves destined by the usages of caste to commit crime and whose descendants will be offenders against law..."

It was only in 1952, that the Government of India officially repealed the CTA, which had by that time been amended a couple of times. The repeal of the Act had led to the denotification of communities classified as "criminal" under the CTA, leading to these groups becoming known as the DNTs.

However, in the same year, India saw the introduction of various habitual offender laws throughout the States, which, while doing away with the hereditary definition of people being compelled to commit crimes, classified certain people as "habitual offenders", leading to the continued targeting of these communities – this time not as "criminal" but as "habitual offenders".

What is the history of their enumeration?

While both the CTA and synchronous Censuses in India began in 1871, it was from 1911 onwards that Census reports started discussing "criminal tribes" specifically. Provincial Census reports from 1911 and 1931 provide an insight into the enumeration of these communities, where they were specifically classified as such. The 1931 Census was, however, the last time these communities were accounted for in the Census exercise. Since the repeal of the CTA and the denotification of the communities,



New group: A demonstration demanding de-notified tribes community certificate in Dindigul, Tamil Nadu, in 2025. G. KARTHIKEYAN

specific enumeration of these communities was done away with in subsequent Censuses, given the Republic's conclusions at the time that it was not necessary to enumerate castes (apart from Scheduled Castes (SC) and Scheduled Tribes (ST)) in Censuses.

But the state's effort to account for these communities had begun even before their official denotification, with the establishment of the Ayyangar Commission in 1949. Since 1952, by which time the concept of backward classes apart from SCs and STs had been introduced, several of the denotified communities were accommodated in these lists as "Vimukt Jatis". Eventually, the decades after India's Independence saw a majority of the denotified communities being assimilated into the SC, ST, or the Other Backward Classes (OBC) lists.

In 1998, author Mahasweta Devi and scholar G.N. Devy constituted the Denotified, Nomadic, and Semi-Nomadic Tribes-Rights Action Group (DNT-RAG), the work of which had led to a technical advisory group on DNTs, and the eventual formation of the first National Commission for DNTs, headed by B.S. Renke. The Commission submitted its report on recommendations to uplift DNTs in 2008. Following this, another national Commission was set up under the leadership of Bhiku Ramji Idate, which submitted its report in 2017. All Commission reports on the subject of DNTs began with the question of identifying and classifying them, before noting that a full, accurate classification and identification exercise was not possible until a Census count was conducted for these communities.

The latest assessment of the communities in the Idate Commission's report had identified close to 1,200 communities that were DNTs, noting that all of these communities had been assimilated into the existing classifications of SCs, STs, and OBCs. Apart from this, the Commission had identified about 268 other denotified communities that had

not been classified at all. A NITI Aayog-commissioned study conducted by the Anthropological Survey of India on these 268 communities had recommended their classifications. But this report has gone into cold storage.

What is their status now?

While in many States, DNTs have been incorporated into backward classes lists, and in SC and ST lists, where certain benefits of policies like reservations may have trickled down to them owing to selective application of sub-classification, State governments have formulated policies specifically targeting them as well. However, community leaders have argued that despite this, the stigma they had been subjected to continued even after their denotification, through the operation of laws like the Habitual Offenders Act. They argue that this led to their continued discrimination, and that they remained largely socially, economically, educationally, and politically backward, except for a few denotified communities that were settled and had used available resources to uplift themselves to a certain extent.

Even though the Idate Commission report had recommended a permanent National Commission for the DNTs, the first Narendra Modi-led government had decided that, since most of these communities had already been included in SC, ST, and OBC lists, a Welfare Board would be sufficient to address their concerns.

The Social Justice Ministry, eventually, also rolled out the SEED scheme for livelihood, education, housing, and health interventions for DNTs. But the government has been able to spend only a fraction of its intended ₹200 crore spending over the last five years. A principal problem with implementing this scheme was that it required an identification of a beneficiary as a DNT, which required them to have a DNT certification that need not be exclusive of the SC, ST, or OBC identities (if they were already included in these lists). The

loudest complaint of the community across States has been that they are not being issued DNT certificates despite continuous reminders and letters from the Central government, with government data showing that only select districts in about half a dozen States issue these certificates.

This has only fed the movement of DNTs across many parts of India seeking a separate Constitutional classification for themselves on par with the SC, ST, and OBC categorisations, arguing that this would then lead to uniform issuance of DNT certificates. Further, this movement has also called for sub-classification within the specific DNT list to recognise uneven backwardness of communities within this grouping.

Moreover, community leaders and associations like the All India Denotified Nomadic Tribes Development Council have been framing their struggle for a separate classification as the need to have their specific discrimination and stigmatisation recognised by the State. In doing so, they have argued that the only reason colonial administrators labelled them "criminal" was because of their insistence on resisting foreign aggressors. Many community leaders have also noted that they had been the first line of defence even before colonialism, and had histories of resisting Islamic rulers as well.

What now?

Apart from assurances to community leaders that they will be counted, there has been no indication as to how this enumeration will take place.

DNT associations have made their demand clear that they want a specific column or question in the Census forms to classify people as DNTs. This demand has found support from scholars like Mr. Devy, who have consistently argued for a separate Census for the DNTs.

However, so far, the Union Government's public statements have indicated that it is not considering any proposal for a separate classification for the DNTs.

THE GIST

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